



ANVIL 

Layout WIP - v01

inside cover

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THE GAME OF ANVIL

WHAT IS IT?

ANVIL is a *fantasy roleplaying game* where you become an *elite dwarven taskforce*, dropping in to hotzones to accomplish missions for the Queen. Within each mission you'll have to successfully *accomplish objectives* while *deciding how covert your squad acts*.

There is *no wrong way to move through a mission*, whether you are skulking through each room expertly dispatching foes without being seen or *blasting your way through walls* and sending deepbeasts back into the abyss what matters is accomplishing the objective. Sure, the Queen's Hand might not be happy with you *lighting off a pile of powder kegs* but that's a problem for later.

Upon succesful return from a mission the job isn't over. You'll navigate the complicated web of agendas throughout the realm to decide who to deal with and when, but not before *crushing a pint of the finest ale* with your squad, *trauma bonding isn't the only way to build relationships*.

ANVIL is about managing your impact, execution and the world's ability to respond to your actions. Every dwarf has a plan until their fuse is cut short. Use any method you can to **drop 'em like stones**.

WHAT YOU NEED

To play **ANVIL** you will need the **printable sheets**, **pencils**, at least **one set of polyhedral (standard ttrpg dice set) dice** and a whole **bunch of d6**.

THE CORE LOOP – HOW TO PLAY

A condensed reference for how a full campaign session flows. Use it as a checklist during play. Full rules for every step are in their respective sections.

PHASE 01 PREP - AT THE OVERHOLD

Each dwarf takes up to *2 Overhold Actions*.

Actions cost Embers from the squad's shared vault. No dwarf may take the same action twice in one downtime. See Overhold Actions for full list and cost.

MISSION BRIEFING

The Hand assigns the mission, players receive *Briefing Intel*: rough layout, primary and secondary objectives, Ember payouts, known faction presence and drop points. Scout intel fills in additional keyed rooms if the action was taken.

LOADOUT

Players fill their *4 item slots* from the prep stash. All operatives begin with a *Runeaxe (CMP d6)* and *Explosives Kit (IMP d6)*. Stash access depends on Squad Reputation. Gear costs Embers at purchase.

PHASE 02 DROP IN

The squad chooses their drop point. Entrances are defined in the mission sheet with characteristics: guarded, trapped, structural, gear-gated. They arrive by Strigwraith or on foot. (Dwarves don't use parachutes, they crash into the earth on parashields.)

GM SETS THE TABLE

- GM starts their Aftermath pool at the *number of players*.
- Heat starts at *0*.
- Beat count starts at *0*.
- Hammers are prepped and ready.

THE CORE LOOP – HOW TO PLAY

PHASE 03 THE MISSION

Each dwarf moves and takes an action. When the outcome is in question, **throw stones**.

Roll CMP and IMP. Assign one die as FUSE, one as BLAST. See throwing stones section for full rules.

EXPLOSIVE ACTIONS [E]

FUSE is detonation time in individual turns. BLAST is how many Explosion dice (ExD) to roll. Heat rises by the full value of the BLAST die, not just 1.

SMOTHER

Both assigned dice show 1 on a standard action – reduce Heat by 3.

STACK UP

Multiple dwarves acting together. Pool all rolled dice, assign one FUSE and one BLAST from the pool. If two or more 6s appear in the full pool, raise Heat by 1 per participating dwarf. Stack Ups cannot trigger Smother unless a rule says otherwise.

BEATS & AFTERMATH

Mark 1 Beat after all players act. Every 3 Beats: GM gains 2 Aftermath dice. **During Shatterpoint this raises to 3 Aftermath dice.** At any point after a player turn the GM may spend Aftermath to throw stones for enemies, traps or the environment. Minimum 2 dice per throw.

THE CORE LOOP – HOW TO PLAY

PHASE 03 THE MISSION

HIT RESOLUTION

BLAST > Temper	Clean hit. Destroys item or fills all 3 marks.
BLAST = Temper	Maim. Fills 1 mark.
BLAST < Temper	Botch. No effect.

Hits land on gear first or skills, then GRIT. Players may choose what absorbs. The fiction should support it.

When a dwarf has no gear or skills left, d3 for both CMP and IMP. GRIT is last. Maim marks 1. A clean hit to GRIT marks all 3 and the dwarf is going down. They take one last action and then their fate is unknown until a squadmate checks on them.

Cold	0-5	No Hammer
Warm	6-10	No Hammer
Hot	11-15	Hammer if prepped
White Hot	16-19	Hammer if prepped
Shatterpoint 20+		Hammer always. Heat cannot be reduced.

HEAT THRESHOLDS

Hammers change mission conditions. They are never just more enemies—they close routes, flip room states, escalate faction behavior, wake something below.

OBJECTIVES MET? EXTRACT.

Extraction is improvised. There is no guaranteed safe exit, but there is always a way out. Hammers may seal options. Shatterpoint is a race.

THE CORE LOOP – HOW TO PLAY

PHASE 04 EXTRACT & DOWNTIME

DEBRIEF

GM and players review the mission together.

- Did Heat hit any Hammer thresholds?
- Primary objective complete?
- Secondary objectives complete?
- Was **ANVIL** exposed? Were civilians or factions involved?
- What rumors spread?

Ember payout is distributed per completed objective.
Squad Reputation shifts based on extraction Heat.

REP SHIFT BY EXTRACTION HEAT

Cold extraction	-2 Rep marks
Warm extraction	-1 Rep mark
Hot extraction	no change
White Hot extraction	+1 Rep mark
Shatterpoint	+2 Rep marks

RECOVERY

All GRIT restored. Surviving dwarves roll for Scars.
Funerals are held. Retirements are named.
Back to Phase 1.

THROWING STONES

COMPOSURE & IMPACT

Every dwarf has two dice: **Composure (CMP)** and **Impact (IMP)**. The base die for both is a d3. All **ANVIL** operatives are assigned a **Runeaxe** and an **Explosives Kit** that raises each die to d6.

Rolling for the results of an action is called throwing stones. When you throw stones you roll both dice and assign one as FUSE and one as BLAST.

As a rule: FUSE is about **how**. BLAST is about **what**.

Assign FUSE to the die that should reflect your control, speed and precision. Assign BLAST to the die that reflects your impact, noise and force. A dwarf can want low FUSE and low BLAST-silent and precise, or low FUSE and high BLAST-fast and destructive. High FUSE is **almost** never what you want: it means the action was slow, messy, or complicated.

A larger die isn't always a buff and a smaller die isn't always bad. Large CMP dice gives more varied Composure results, a dwarf who is less steady. Smaller IMP dice give smaller BLAST, a weaker hit, a smaller explosion.

YOU WANT TO...	ASSIGNED DIE LOGIC...
Move quietly	FUSE (lower = you get further)
Hit hard through armour	BLAST (higher = more force)
Execute cleanly in combat	FUSE (lower = clean and swift)
Make noise as a distraction	BLAST (higher = louder)
Negotiate with an NPC	FUSE (lower beats Posture)
Set a charge with a long delay	FUSE (higher = more time)
Blow something up right now	FUSE (lower = immediate)
Cause maximum damage	BLAST (higher = more dice)
Keep Heat down	BLAST (lower = no Heat raise)

THROWING STONES

ROLL TYPES AND EFFECTS

STANDARD ACTIONS

Standard actions are for any action that is uncertain and is not Explosive [E].

ROLL	ASSIGN	EFFECT
CMP + IMP	One die = FUSE	Execution quality. Lower is cleaner.
	One die = BLAST	Impact. 4+ raises Heat. Checked vs Temper.
Both 1s	-	Smother. Heat -3.

EXPLOSIVE ACTIONS

Using gear marked [E] is an Explosive action. Throw stones as normal, then roll Explosion dice (ExD) based on the BLAST die value.

ROLL	ASSIGN	EFFECT
CMP + IMP	FUSE	Turns until detonation.
	BLAST	Number of ExD to roll.
Explosion Dice	-	4+ = hit. 6s explode, roll again. All dice become GM Aftermath.

SMOTHER

If a dwarf performs a standard action and assigns two 1s, reduce the Heat gauge by 3.

There is no “correct” assignment. Every roll is a trade-off between how cleanly something happens and how much chaos it creates. That tension is ANVIL’s core.

THROWING STONES

ROLL TYPES AND EFFECTS

STACK UP

A squad may combine their turns to act together for a standard action. Each player throws stones. All results are pooled. Assign FUSE and BLAST as normal. If **two or more 6s** appear anywhere across the full pool, Heat gauge +1 for each participating dwarf. Stack Up cannot trigger Smother.

GROUP ROLLS

A Group Roll is called by the GM, not chosen by the squad. It follows Stack Up rules for rolling and assigning, but is **treated as a single throw stones** for all outcomes and consequences. Smother may trigger on a Group Roll.

TEMPER

There is no health or armour in **ANVIL**, only Temper. This represents something's ability to resist impact.

- **The value:** BLAST threshold. BLAST must equal or beat this to affect the target. No value means it cannot be handled by standard actions.
- **The brackets:** Explosive threshold. The number of [+] symbols is how many Explosion Dice hits destroy it. No brackets always means one successful hit destroys it. An Explosive hit is a clean hit.

RESULT	EFFECT
BLAST > Temper	Clean hit. Fills all marks on target.
BLAST = Temper	Maim. Fill 1 mark on target.
BLAST < Temper	Botch. Miss, glance, no effect.

Examples:

T2: BLAST 2+ to handle, one Explosive hit destroys.
T2[++]: BLAST 2+ to handle, two Explosive hits destroy.
T[++]: Cannot be handled by standard actions
Two Explosive hits destroy.
T4[++]: BLAST 4+ to handle, two Explosive hits destroy.

THROWING STONES

HEAT

Every mission has a Heat gauge. Heat rises when players assign a BLAST die of 4, 5, or 6 or by using Explosives [E]. When Heat hits certain thresholds, the Hammer drops.

COLD 0-5 NO HAMMER	WARM 6-10 NO HAMMER	HOT 11-15 POSSIBLE HAMMER	WHITE HOT 16-19 POSSIBLE HAMMER	SHATTERPOINT 20+ HAMMER ALWAYS
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Each mission has specific Hammer events triggered by reaching Heat stages. Hammers warp mission conditions, the squad will need to improvise.

SHATTERPOINT

At **20+ Heat** missions reach Shatterpoint. The mission will begin collapsing around the squad. Every exit is watched, every door barred, something big wakes. Some missions have Hammers at Hot and White Hot but every mission has a climactic Shatterpoint Hammer. Missions at Shatterpoint **cannot have their Heat reduced**.

AFTERMATH & BEATS

AFTERMATH POOLS

Aftermath dice are a **pool of d6** used by the GM to react and let the world put pressure on the players.

A GM may **spend** or **discard** Aftermath dice for various moves. Spending means taking them from the pool and throwing stones. Discarding means removing them from the pool without throwing.

The GM must spend a **minimum of 2 aftermath dice** to throw stones. Spent dice are removed. If a pool has fewer than 2 dice, a GM cannot throw stones. There is no minimum on discarding Aftermath dice. All Aftermath dice (including Squad) are reset between missions.

GENERATING AFTERMATH

- **Mission start:** Gain Aftermath dice equal to number of players.
- **Every 3 Beats:** Gain 2 Aftermath dice.
- **Any assigned 6s:** Gain 1 Aftermath if a throw stones contains 6s.
- **Explosion Dice:** Gain Aftermath dice equal to any Explosion Dice rolled.

SPENDING AFTERMATH

Aftermath dice are used to: attack or threaten the squad with NPCs, trigger traps, cause environmental effects, anything that actively pushes back against the squad.

SQUAD AFTERMATH

Some skills and situations may grant Squad Aftermath dice. These are kept separate from the GM's pool. Any dwarf may take 1 Squad Aftermath die before rolling to add it to their throw stones dice pool. Assign FUSE and BLAST as normal, discard the unused die from the pool.

AFTERMATH & BEATS

FREE MOVES

The GM can make a free move at any time without needing Aftermath. Free moves are effectively foreshadowing the world around the squad.

- Free moves never directly threaten or act against players.
- They are passive actions happening within the mission.
- Something costs Aftermath when it is actively acting against the squad.

Free Move Examples

A patrol completes its route and begins again.

A light goes out or comes on.

A door closes or locks.

An enemy becomes suspicious but takes no action.

The environment shifts: water rising, fire spreads, rubble settles.

An NPC makes a decision that does not affect players yet.

TIME AND BEATS

Time within the world is not specifically tracked in **ANVIL**. The Heat gauge and Agendas pace this for us. A GM needs only pay attention to player turns:

- **Moving and taking an action is a player turn.**
- Mark 1 Beat after all players have had a turn.
- Gain 2 Aftermath dice **every 3 Beats**.

A player doesn't always have to take an action for a Beat to happen as the game flows along naturally. Sometimes you need to ask a player "what are you doing while this happens?" to nudge them along.

COMBAT, DAMAGE & STAYING ALIVE

HOW COMBAT WORKS

Combat is **not a separate phase**. There is no initiative, no combat round and no turn order. Players act freely and describe what they're doing and a GM can react with Aftermath dice as normal.

When something attacks they describe their action and **throw stones**. Low FUSE is a quick clean execution, high FUSE turns into a brawl.

SIMULTANEOUS ATTACKS

If two entities wish to attack at the same time, the lower FUSE hits first. If tied the higher BLAST hits first. If still tied, roll a d6: 1-3 the enemy goes first, 4-6 the player goes first.

FALLING DAMAGE

Dwarves are stout and sturdy. When a dwarf falls, roll 1 Explosive die for every 10 feet fallen.

TEMPER IN COMBAT

Every dwarf has a base Temper of **T3**. Skills and gear can modify this.

ENEMY	TEMPER
Guard in leather	T2
Guard in chainmail	T3
Guard in blast resistant platemail	T4[++]
Hulking deepbeast	T5[+++]

COMBAT, DAMAGE & STAYING ALIVE

MITIGATING DAMAGE

Clean hits and maims can be mitigated by gear, skills and GRIT.

- The fiction must support the mitigation.
- Players should describe why the gear or skill is taking the hit.
- When no gear or skills can be marked, the damage marks GRIT.
- Enemy gear and skills absorb hits just like players.
- Enemy gear has 3 marks unless noted otherwise.
- All enemies have 3 GRIT unless noted otherwise.

Reminder:

BLAST above Temper: Clean hit. Fills all marks on target.

BLAST equals Temper: Maim. Fill 1 mark on target.

BLAST below Temper: Botch. Miss, glance, no effect.

An Explosion die hit is treated as a clean hit.

GEAR & SKILLS

All gear and skills have 3 marks. When gear marks are full it is unavailable for the rest of the mission. A dwarf with no gear rolls d3 for both CMP and IMP. A skill can still be used until all three marks are filled. Filled marks on skills do not clear unless the Release Steam downtime action is taken. A skillless dwarf is still capable, they've just lost their edge.

Enemies and traps can target skills or gear directly. Disorienting gas does not damage armour, a veteran interrogator attacks your mind, not your gear. A smart guard may attempt to ignite your satchel charges.

GRIT

GRIT is a dwarf's final resolve. Every dwarf starts with **3 GRIT**.

- **Clean hit to GRIT:** marks all GRIT.
- **Maim to GRIT:** marks 1 GRIT.

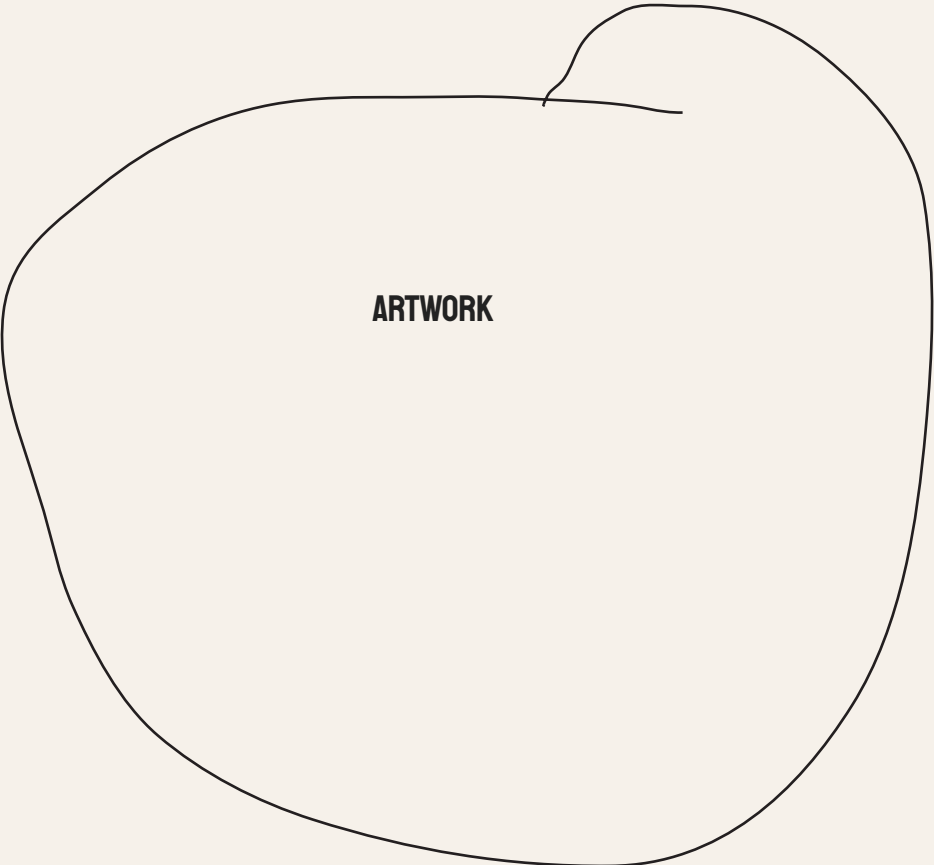
COMBAT, DAMAGE & STAYING ALIVE

DEATH

When a dwarf marks their final GRIT they are going down. They may immediately take one last action. It must be plausible given their position and condition. They may choose to **reroll their throw stones** once.

Then they roll a d6 in a cup. Do not reveal the roll. When a squadmate attempts to check on them, they may peek at the hidden die. On a result of 1-4 the dwarf is gone forever. On a result of 5-6 they are unconscious.

A dwarf may choose to knock a target unconscious if the target would mark their last GRIT.



ARTWORK

SOCIAL INTERACTIONS

POSTURE & TENSION

Every NPC has a Posture on a scale of 1 to 6, **by default they sit at 3**. If a GM wants variance, roll a d6.

LVL POSTURE

- | | |
|------------|--|
| 6 | Hostile: will attack or raise alarm immediately. |
| 5 | Suspicious: one wrong move triggers violence or panic. |
| 4 | Wary: cautious, alert, unstable. |
| X 3 | Neutral: uncertain, controllable. |
| 2 | Friendly: cooperative under pressure. |
| 1 | Trusting: compliant and helpful. |

Tension: []-[]-[]

Every NPC also has a Tension gauge that fills if the squad isn't keeping their cool. If the Tension gauge fills, the NPC breaks:

- **1-2 (Trusting/Friendly):** complies or submits
- **3-4 (Neutral/Wary):** flees or disengages
- **5-6 (Suspicious/Hostile):** attacks or raises alarm

SOCIAL INTERACTIONS

SOCIAL ROLLS

Whether negotiation, deception or intimidation, if a dwarf's intention is to manipulate an NPC throw stones.

- FUSE lower than Posture: Shift 1 towards Trusting.
- FUSE equal Posture: No change.
- FUSE higher than Posture: Shift 1 towards Hostile.
- BLAST 4-6: Mark a Tension.
- If White Hot or Shatterpoint, BLAST 2+ marks Tension.
- A GM can discard 1 Aftermath Die to mark a Tension.
- NPC Posture does not reset between missions.
- Squads can reset Posture through using disguises or Overhold Actions.

Much like Heat and Hammers, Break is not a failure state, it is resolution and heightened pressure on the players. Low Posture enemies can become tools, high Posture enemies can become liabilities.

MOVING THROUGH ENVIRONMENTS

ENVIRONMENT TAGS

Apply these tags to rooms for quick reference.

TAG	DESCRIPTION	EFFECT
[DARK]	Dim or no light.	Standard action FUSE die +2.
[SCALD]	Superheated areas, the air is hot.	[E] BLAST die +2.
[FLOOD]	Rising/standing water.	Moving costs an action. [E] FUSE die +2. Dropped items sink.
[FOG]	Low visibility.	Stealth BLAST die -2. Ranged FUSE die +2.
[BRIGHT]	No cover, fully lit.	Movement raises Heat +1. Stack Up adds 1 Heat when initiated.
[TOXIC]	Poisonous air.	Without protection, IMP dice here are d8.
[UNSTABLE]	Structures are weak.	On [E] BLAST 6 roll d6: 4-6 one exit becomes blocked.
[VERT]	Multi-level, vertical area.	Moving between levels is vertical.
[FORT]	Reinforced and prepared.	Structures here require an extra [++] to destroy.
[DEEPTOUCH]	Area is corrupted.	CMP dice here are d10.
[HIDDEN]	Something is hidden here.	Dwarves can search for this or find out from intel.

MOVING THROUGH ENVIRONMENTS

CHASES

When the squad is pursued the GM places a d6 on the table. The value is how far the pursuers are from the squad. The GM decides based on the narrative. A close pursuer starts the die at 2. A pursuer two rooms back starts it at 4.

Each Beat the chase is active the squad describes how they run and makes a **Group Roll**. The GM then rolls a d6 for the pursuers against the squad's assigned FUSE and BLAST.

- Pursuer d6 under FUSE: pursuer gains ground, move die down 1.
- Pursuer d6 over FUSE: squad makes ground, move die up 1.
- Pursuer d6 over BLAST: pursuers have line of sight, GM may make one free Aftermath move this Beat.

When the die reaches 6 the squad breaks contact and the chase ends. When the die reaches 1 the pursuers catch the squad.

The GM may discard Aftermath to move the die down 1 outside the pursuer roll, or to cancel a move to 6 before the squad escapes.

Smother during a chase moves the die up 1 and breaks line of sight if it has been established.

MOVING THROUGH ENVIRONMENTS

ENCUMBRANCE

When carrying something the size of a dwarf or larger:

- roll an extra d6 when throwing stones
- discard the lowest die before assigning FUSE and BLAST

TWO DWARVES CARRYING

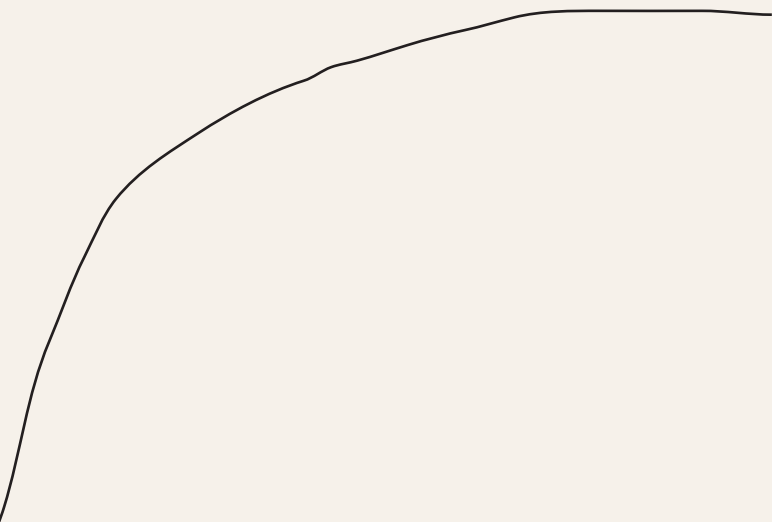
When two dwarves carry the penalty applies to both. Both throw stones with an extra d6, both discard the lowest die, then pool the dice together and assign.

MULTIPLE LARGE THINGS

If a dwarf is carrying multiple large things: roll an extra d6 for each item, discard a number of lowest dice equal to how many items carried, assign as normal.



ARTWORK



CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

AN ANVIL OPERATIVES FOUNDATION

Roll on each table and mark the results on your Operative Sheet, then add 2 Ember to the Overhold's Ember vault.

Ultimately a player may choose the result themselves but generally more interesting characters will come from letting the dice decide your dwarf.

Your dwarf will end up with:

- A codename and real name.
- A physique.
- A trinket.
- A personality and a fear.
- A Runeaxe and Explosives Kit.
- Three skills.
- Four gear slots to fill from stash.
- 2 Ember in the Ember Vault.

CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

CODENAMES - D66

D66	CODENAME	D66	CODENAME
11	Tombstone	41	Duskrock
12	Cinder	42	Grimbeard
13	Patchwork	43	Lowburn
14	Slag	44	Ironlung
15	Crowbar	45	Buckshot
16	Dustcoat	46	Greasefire
21	Coalbreath	51	Blacktooth
22	Lowstone	52	Coldsnap
23	Sootnose	53	Roughcut
24	Trollbuster	54	Hammerfall
25	Notch	55	Ashpit
26	Copperhead	56	Oreborn
31	Clinker	61	Sparrow
32	Ghostbeard	62	Pockmark
33	Flint	63	Shortfuse
34	Deadweight	64	Grumble
35	Brimstone	65	Halfmark
36	Knuckle	66	Lastlight

CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

REAL NAMES - D66

D66	NAME	D66	NAME
11	Aldric	41	Maren
12	Bryndis	42	Osrold
13	Corra	43	Petra
14	Dunvik	44	Ragnis
15	Edda	45	Brulnys
16	Fenrik	46	Tjorba
21	Grimlyl	51	Ulla
22	Halva	52	Veska
23	Ingrid	53	Wulfar
24	Balnir	54	Urmdek
25	Keld	55	Ysolde
26	Rynwin	56	Zarvik
31	Gragnus	61	Brek
32	Norda	62	Dagna
33	Orvyn	63	Elka
34	Mistvar	64	Grimur
35	Queld	65	Hesta
36	Runa	66	Ivar

Players should adjust or tweak their dwarf’s real names to best fit how they envision their character.

CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

BUILD - D6

D6	BUILD
1	Compact. Low centre of gravity, built like a clenched fist.
2	Broad. Shoulders like a doorframe.
3	Wiry. Slender and sharp, stronger than you look.
4	Heavy. Dense, things that hit you seem surprised.
5	Lean. Tall for a dwarf, agile and quick.
6	Irregular. A slight lean, a crooked gait.

FACE - D6

D6	FACE
1	Flat and broad, nose broken at least twice, eyes set deep.
2	Sharp features, prominent brow, jaw like a shovel.
3	Round and weathered, wrinkles from squinting at the forge.
4	Asymmetrical. One ear lower, one eye that droops.
5	Gaunt. Sharp cheekbones, sunken eyes.
6	Soft featured. Rosy cheeks and big eyes.

BEARD - D6

D6	BEARD
1	None. Clean shaven by choice or by circumstance.
2	Short and dense, oiled flat, practical.
3	Full and long, braided once, coming loose.
4	Patchy. Either hereditary or from explosive mishaps.
5	Elaborate. Rings, beads, ribbons all woven in.
6	Burned or cut short on one side.

CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

TRINKETS, WHAT YOU HAVE - D66

D66	TRINKET	D66	TRINKET
11	Dented thimble	41	Folded letter
12	Chipped tooth	42	Worn badge
13	Copper coin	43	Cracked lens
14	Knotted cord	44	Pressed flower
15	Tin flask	45	Broken watch
16	Iron ring	46	Carved bone
21	Child's drawing	51	Wax seal
22	Burnt photograph	52	Loose button
23	Stone chip	53	Dried herb
24	Dog tags	54	Splinter of wood
25	Folded map	55	Betting slip
26	Tavern token	56	Stamped tin
31	Crumpled note	61	Snapped blade
32	Small key	62	Painted stone
33	Glass eye	63	Tuft of braided hair
34	Coal chunk	64	Scrap of uniform
35	Bone die	65	Half a medal
36	Shard of stained glass	66	Nothing

CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

PERSONALITY, HOW YOU OPERATE - D66

D66	PERSONALITY	D66	PERSONALITY
11	Brooding	41	Reckless
12	Gruff	42	Loyal
13	Bitter	43	Haunted
14	Steady	44	Proud
15	Wry	45	Cold
16	Volatile	46	Measured
21	Stubborn	51	Hollow
22	Shrewd	52	Relentless
23	Tired	53	Superstitious
24	Warm	54	Detached
25	Sharp	55	Methodical
26	Grieving	56	Wrathful
31	Quiet	61	Earnest
32	Suspicious	62	Fractured
33	Devout	63	Hungry
34	Weary	64	Distant
35	Sardonic	65	Unbroken
36	Reckless	66	Spent

CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

FEARS

When the fiction puts a dwarf face to face with their Fear they have a choice: push through it and accomplish their goal or give into it and let it shape what happens.

When a dwarf **acts on their Fear** and it creates a genuine narrative moment, the GM may award 1 Squad Aftermath. When **a squadmate actively engages** with that dwarf in that moment, not watching, not waiting but responding to who that dwarf is right now, they may fill 1 Bond mark. The GM decides both, neither is automatic.

D12	FEAR	MANIFEST
1	Claustrophobia	Tight spaces. Something shuts off and you stop thinking clearly.
2	Abandonment	Whether principle or compulsion you don't leave people.
3	Immolation	Flames scare something in you in a way other danger don't.
4	Collateral	You will not let a bystander or innocent die on your watch.
5	Authority	You're suspicious of folks in power.
6	Corruption	You're not afraid of Deepbeasts, you're afraid of the effect they leave.
7	Solitude	Being the last one left, you've been there before and it won't happen again.
8	Collapse	You check the ceiling, you check the walls. You don't go in until you do.
9	Obligation	You cannot walk away from someone asking for help.
10	Dissolution	When things fall apart you begin to lose yourself.
11	Vendetta	A faction, a sigil, a colour. Something they did you haven't put down.
12	Nyctophobia	The dark. Not as a tactical problem, just the lone, quiet dark.

CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

SKILLS

Skills represent what a dwarf has trained in and what they're good at. Each skill has: a name, a creed, a mechanical permission, three fortification slots and three marks.

Roll 3 skills from the d66 table.

During downtime, **a dwarf may spend Embers to level skills.** For full details, view the Fortify Overhold Action.

Extend (-)

Applies to additional dwarves, not just you.

Deepen (≡)

Triggers in one additional situation or context.

Sharpen (x)

Becomes more reliable, efficient or decisive.

Linger (··)

Persists into the next Beat or related action.

Bend (-)

Adds one exception to a core rule, once per mission.

Survive (^)

A fourth skill mark can be added by circumstance.

CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

SKILLS

II-16 COLD OPS

Stealth, Heat Control, Smother

11 Skulk

"I disappear between heartbeats."

May reroll 1 CMP die while obscured, hiding or out of sight.

12 Ashcloak

"I leave no trace, make no sound."

Your Smother triggers on 1-1 or 1-2.

13 Shadow Axe

"I know every blind spot before entering a room."

Once per mission, a BLAST of 4+ does not raise any Heat.

14 Dead Quiet

"I lock in exactly when it counts."

Once per mission, reduce your assigned FUSE by 3.

15 Ghost Pact

"I am unseen, unheard, undeniable."

First Aftermath action targeting you each Beat the GM must discard 1 Aftermath to throw stones.

16 Cold Read

"I have internalized the mission brief."

Once per mission, gain 1 intel about the mission from the GM.

CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

SKILLS

21-26 BREACHERS

Explosives, Heat Weaponization, Destruction

21 Smoke Eater

"I thrive when the air is black."

Once per mission, ignore one Heat rise entirely.

22 Controlled Burn

"I contain fire and use it."

Assigning explosive BLAST 6 gives 1 Squad Aftermath.

23 Fuse Cutter

"I have steady hands and steady blasts."

Once per mission, treat assigned FUSE as 2 or 3.

24 Overpacked

"I bring extra explosives, for fun."

On Explosive actions, may reroll IMP die, must keep new result.

25 Demolition Expert

"I know every wall's weak points."

Explosive actions against structures ignore one [+].

26 Pressure Cook

"I believe chaos is the best ingredient."

When a Hammer drops, gain Squad Aftermath equal to current Heat tier.

CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

SKILLS

31-36 ANCHORS

Temper, Survival, Absorption

31 Ironbuilt

"I am built like the mountain."

Gain 1 additional GRIT.

32 Stoneback

"I am immovable when stuck in."

If this dwarf did not move this turn, Temper +2.

33 Blastcoat

"I am prepared for the worst."

Once per mission, when gear would be destroyed by a clean hit, maim it instead.

34 Rune Bracing

"I am always ready for impact."

Once per mission, redirect a hit targeting an adjacent dwarf to you instead.

35 Last Wall

"I am first in, last out."

When on final GRIT, Temper increases by 2.

36 Deep Plate

"I am built for the collapse."

Temper 5 against environmental damage: cave-ins, flood, fire, pressure, environmental collapse.

CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

SKILLS

41-46 HANDLERS

Aftermath, Social, Intel

41 Counterintel

"I know how the enemy thinks."

Once per mission, remove 3 dice from the GM's Aftermath pool.

42 Tunnel Sense

"I hear things coming."

Once per mission, after the GM declares an Aftermath move, may act before it resolves.

43 Loud and Proud

"My confidence is contagious."

BLAST 4-5 never marks an NPC's Tension.

44 Interrogator

"I get what I need one way or another."

May intentionally mark a Tension to extract one piece of intel from an NPC.

45 Iron Nerves

"I never flinch, I never react."

Ignore the first Aftermath action targeting you each mission.

46 Black Lung Humor

"I laugh through the pain."

Once per mission after a failed interaction, either reduce Posture by 1 OR clear 1 Tension mark.

CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

SKILLS

51-56 FORGELORDS

Gear, Prep, Logistics

51 Pack Rat

"I carry more than anyone thinks possible."

One [B] item only takes 1 slot.

52 Salvager

"I keep my gear intact."

After extraction, recover any one destroyed item from the mission.

53 Quickpatch

"I fix things fast, instead of not at all."

Clear 1 mark from any damaged gear once per mission.

54 Sacrificial Rigging

"I know what's worth burning."

Destroy a piece of gear to reduce Heat by 2.

55 Steady Mule

"I always keep my legs moving."

The encumbrance penalty does not apply to this dwarf.

56 Requisitioner

"I know how to pull strings at the Overhold."

Once per downtime, reduce the cost of a stash item by 1 Ember.

CREATING A DWARF OPERATIVE

SKILLS

21-26 FLAMETOUCHED

Shatterpoint Survival, Hammer Interaction, Escalation

61 Anvilborn

"I was forged in the worst of it."

Immediately after a Hammer drops, your CMP die becomes d4 until the mission ends.

62 Temper Gauge

"I feel the mission tipping before it does."

Once per mission, GM must reveal the next Hammer effect before it triggers.

63 Coal Walker

"I operate best when everything's on fire."

While Heat is White Hot or higher, FUSE results of 5-6 count as 4.

64 Cragrunner

"I was built to find exits."

During Shatterpoint, this dwarf knows a guaranteed escape route if not incapacitated.

65 Furnace Crew

"I can buy the squad one more breath."

The first Hammer drop each mission is delayed by 2 Heat.

66 White Irons

"I have been here before and walked out."

Once per mission, treat a clean hit to GRIT as a maim instead.

BONDS

HOW BONDS WORK

Dwarves build Bonds through surviving missions together and spending time together at Overhold.

This is tracked separately for each dwarf on their Op Sheet. Each Bond level **requires 2 marks to advance**.

When joining the squad, all dwarves fill 1 Bond mark.

ADVANCING BONDS

- **Share Hearth downtime action**. Fills 1 Bond mark.
- **Surviving a mission at White Hot or Shatterpoint**. All dwarves fill 1 Bond mark.
- **Engaging with a squadmates Fear** fills 1 Bond mark.

BOND TRACKING

Squad bond is tracked on the bottom of the Operative sheet. Each box represents one level of bond.

As long as you have at least half a box filled, that level is active.

○ ○ ○	GEAR Cigars					
⊗ ○ ○	1ST KIN Ragnis					
SQUAD BOND	2	X	X			

BONDS

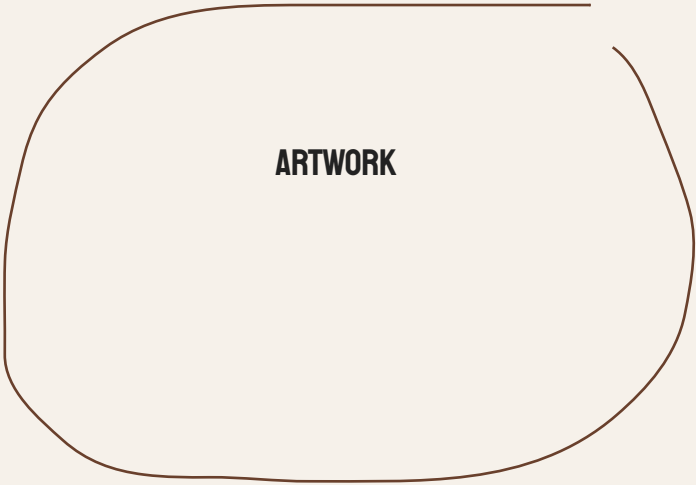
BOND LEVELS

LEVEL	EFFECT
1	Bonded. May Stack Up with squad.
2	Ignore Encumbrance in Stack Up.
3	You do not generate Aftermath from double 6s in Stack Up.
4	Once per mission, you may redirect a maim from a squadmate to yourself.
5	During Stack Up, your assigned dice may trigger Smother.

KINSHIP

At character creation, **each dwarf chooses a first of kin** and marks them on their Op sheet.

A dwarf may **reroll CMP or IMP** once per mission **when interacting with this dwarf**.



GEAR & STASH

RUNEAXE & EXPLOSIVES KIT

Dwarves are **assigned** a Runeaxe and an Explosives Kit **when they become operatives**.

These items aren't just weapons, **they're tools** and the foundation of any **ANVIL** operatives loadout. They have a high Ember cost to replace, take care of them.

RUNEAXE

- Your main weapon and tool.
- Raises your base CMP die to d6.

EXPLOSIVES KIT

- The only explosive gear that is not [~].
- Raises your base IMP die to d6.
- Additional and different explosives can be taken from the stash.

Both the Runeaxe and the Explosives Kit can be upgraded and modified with the Forge downtime action.

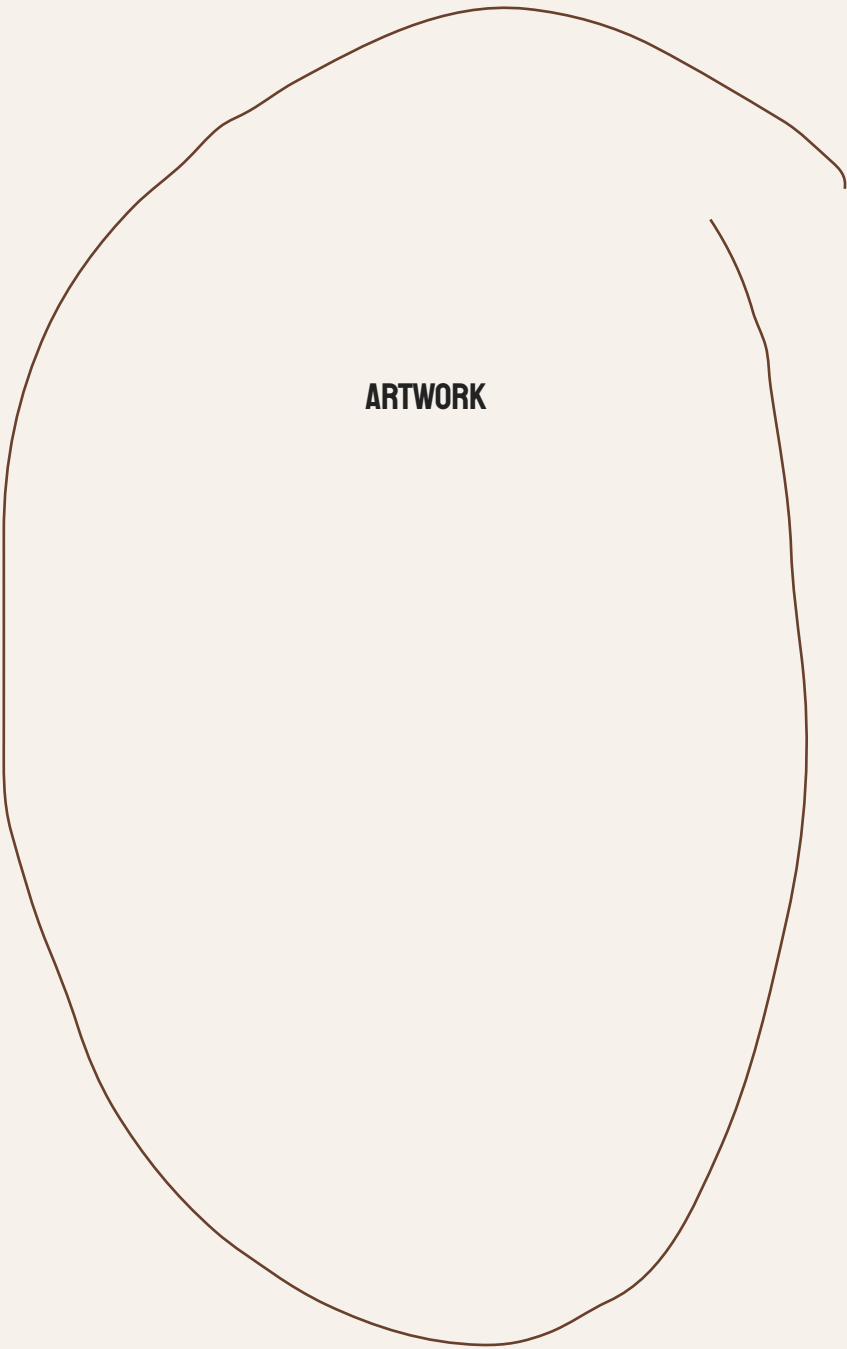
OVERHOLD STASH

The Overhold maintains a stash of equipment available between missions. The GM maintains the stash list. It grows and shrinks with the campaign. Higher Rep tiers unlock deeper stash access. Oddities are never guaranteed and always at GM discretion.

Players may also use the Forge downtime action to work with the GM to create custom gear.

- Contents depend on Squad Reputation and Ember investment during downtime.
- The stash is not a shop, dwarves do not browse it.
- ANVIL decides what is available and they requisition what they need.

For the full stash list see page XX.



ARTWORK

RUNNING MISSIONS

HOW MISSIONS WORK

Missions are one shot dungeons that generally take one session to complete.

- The squad is assigned an objective by the Hand.
- They're given what intel exists.
- They drop in.
- They complete objectives.
- They extract.

Every mission has **a map and a sheet**. The sheet handles the macro structure. The map handles the room level detail. **Successful objectives** and completed missions **earn the squad Embers**, which are used to take downtime actions and purchase stash gear.

INTEL TIERS

The squad is **given partial intel**. They can use the **Scout downtime action** to learn more.

BRIEFING INTEL

Provided by the Hand at mission assignment. Official, possibly outdated and occasionally wrong.

Gives: rough map layout, primary objective, known faction presence, recommended drop points.

SCOUT INTEL

Firsthand reconnaissance gathered during downtime via the Scout action. Is always reliable.

Can fill in: patrol routes, enemy Temper values, entrance details, secondary objective locations.

The squad's pre-mission map is a partial key. Rooms they have intel on are filled in. Everything else is dark until they move through it. **Players can see their entry point and any directly adjacent rooms**. Scout intel is represented as additional keyed rooms.

RUNNING MISSIONS

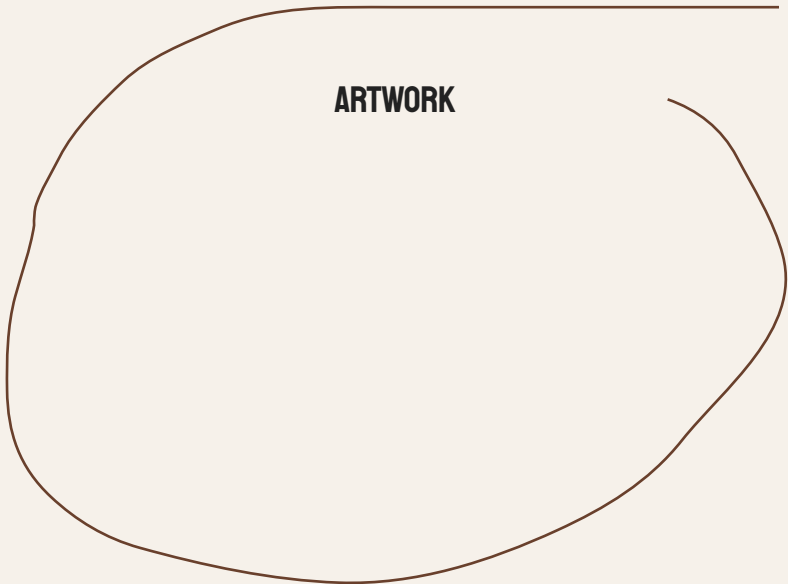
DROP POINTS AND EXTRACTION

The **squad chooses** their drop point from available **entrances during Prep**. Entrances are defined on the mission sheet with characteristics:

- Guarded entrances have patrols stationed.
- Structural entrances require breaching.
- Unique entrances require specific gear or skills to use.
- Some entrances are a mix of all three.

The squad can drop in via Strigwraiths, giant owls with silent flight, or they can move in on foot. The choice is theirs.

Extraction is improvised, the squad knows the exits but gets out however they can. A Hammer may close options, seal routes, or change what extraction looks like entirely, there is no guaranteed exit but **there is always the ability to get out**.



ARTWORK

RUNNING MISSIONS

THE MISSION SHEET

The GM should fill in the mission sheet during prep. Room level detail lives on the keyed map.

MISSION NAME AND TYPE

Name the mission and assign it an objective type from the d8 table.

OBJECTIVES

Every mission has one primary objective and up to three secondary objectives. Ember payout is assigned per objective and revealed during briefing.

EMBER PAYOUT GUIDANCE

Missions should pay out enough for each dwarf to take 2 Overhold Actions and get 2-3 gear per downtime without clearing every objective. The target is 5-7~ Embers per dwarf per downtime.

- **Primary objective:** 3 Embers per dwarf. Completing only primary should be able to cover basic downtime needs.
- **Each secondary objective:** 2 Embers per dwarf. Two secondaries plus primary puts the squad in a comfortable position.
- **Full completion bonus:** 1 Ember per dwarf. A windfall that rewards clean play without making feeling mandatory.

Adjust by mission weight. A harder or more complex mission warrants a primary payout of 4 and secondaries of 2-3. A shorter or lower stakes mission can sit at 2/1/1.

Primary should always **be worth more** than a **secondary**.

RUNNING MISSIONS

THE MISSION SHEET

THE KEYED MAP

The GM draws the map and assigns each room or area a number. Each number corresponds to a key entry. Keep entries functional and just lean enough to run.

ANVIL

CLASSIFIED

MISSION BRIEF

MISSION

LOCATION

PRIMARY

SECONDARY

SECONDARY

SECONDARY

FULL

BRIEFING INTEL

SCOUT INTEL

FACTION & ACTIVITY

COLD

TYPE

EMBER

EMBER

EMBER

EMBER

EMBER

[11+]HAMMER

[16+]HAMMER

[20+]HAMMER

ACCESS POINTS

EXTRACTION NOTES

MAP

HEAT GAUGE

NUM.

TITLE

CONNECTS TO

DESC.

NOTES

STRUCTURE TEMPER

TAGS

RUNNING MISSIONS

OBJECTIVE TYPES - D8

1. EXTRACTION

Get a target out, dead or alive depends on the mission. Primary success is the target leaves with the squad.

Complications: target is unwilling, target is fragile.

2. ELIMINATION

Remove a specific target permanently. Primary success is confirmed removal.

Complications: target is protected, target is mobile.

3. SABOTAGE

Destroy, disable or corrupt something. Primary success is the thing no longer functions.

Complications: is guarded, destroying it has consequences, must look like an accident.

4. RECOVERY

Retrieve something without destroying it. Primary success is the object leaves intact.

Complications: object is large, fragile, cursed, contested by another faction.

RUNNING MISSIONS

OBJECTIVE TYPES - D8

5. SURVEILLANCE

Observe without being observed. Primary success is leaving with the intel.

Complications: target is unpredictable, observation window is limited, squad cannot engage.

6. INTERRUPTION

Stop something from happening. Primary success is the event never occurs.

Complications: squad does not know exactly when, multiple triggers exist, stopping it causes fallout.

7. ESCORT

Get someone through hostile territory alive. Primary success is delivery.

Complications: target is a liability, they generate Heat, they have their own agenda.

8. INFILTRATION

Get in, complete a task, get out without raising any alarms. Primary success is zero trace.

Heat management is the entire mission, success if Cold or Warm. The squad can still escape if Hot+ but the rewards will reflect that.

RUNNING MISSIONS

HEAT & HAMMERS

When players raise the Heat gauge, the world reacts accordingly.

STAGEV	HEAT	HAMMER
Cold	0-5	None
Warm	6-10	None
Hot	11-15	Optional
White Hot	16-19	Optional
Shatterpoint	20+	Always

- Every mission needs a Shatterpoint Hammer.
- Hot and White Hot Hammers are optional but recommended for anything longer than six rooms.
- Hammers should radically change mission conditions.
- Write the specific hammer for your mission on the sheet.
- Define what changes, what closes, what activates and what the squad has to deal with.

HEAT & HAMMERS

HAMMER CHECKLIST

- Does the Hammer change the physical space? (routes close, rooms flood, ceilings fall)
- Does the Hammer change faction behavior? (reinforcements, elite units, full alert)
- Does the Hammer affect at least one objective? (the target moves, the item is destroyed, the window closes)
- Is the Hammer something the players caused, not something that happens to them passively?

Hammers should feel like consequences of the squad's impact, not arbitrary escalation.

Write each Hammer as a concrete event: what happens, what changes, what the squad now has to deal with.

ARTWORK

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

Between missions **ANVIL** ops return to the Overhold. A large brutalist structure on the northwest edge of Glimmerhold, low forge smoke hangs in the air in every room. The Queen employs ANVIL and her Hand runs it, the Glimmerhold council does not know it exists.

Downtime is not rest. It is recovery, politics, preparation and grief. It is your job between the jobs.

EMBERS

Embers are **ANVIL's** downtime currency. After completing missions all Embers go into the squad's **shared vault**. Squads can bank Embers between missions.

A dwarf may **burn Embers to take downtime actions** or acquire gear from the stash. These Embers are gone **permanently**.

DOWNTIME STRUCTURE

STEP 1 **DEBRIEF**.

The squad reviews the mission with the Hand or their assigned handler. Players and GM work through the following questions together:

- Did Heat reach any Hammer thresholds?
- Was the primary objective completed?
- Were secondary objectives completed?
- Was ANVIL exposed or were civilians or factions involved?
- What rumors spread as a result?

The GM narrates campaign consequences.

This phase resolves: Ember payout, Squad Reputation, Sets context of future missions.

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

DOWNTIME STRUCTURE

STEP 2 RECOVERY.

Resolve Scars, funerals, retirements and decompression. This phase has **no rolls** unless a dwarf is rolling for Scars.

Give this phase some space. A dwarf down to their last GRIT and made it out needs a moment. A squad that lost someone needs a funeral. **Name the dead**, describe the funeral anvil and let the silence sit.

If a dwarf dies mid mission a player may roll up a new op immediately. The table decides how they join the mission in progress. Whether captive, a rogue operative, or a side cell also on the mission, etc. Make sure the party joins up and **works together** with them immediately.

- All GRIT is fully recovered here.
- Dwarves who retire here roll a new operative.
- Any player who's dwarf died during the mission rolls a new operative here.

STEP 3 OVERHOLD ACTIONS.

Each dwarf may take up to **2 actions during downtime**. No dwarf may take the same action twice. Actions require Embers burned from the squad's vault.

STEP 4 PREP.

The squad reviews the next mission briefing together. Players interact with: mission objectives and Ember payout, the prep stash and available gear, loadout selection, drop plan and extraction route.

Gear in the prep stash is available to requisition. Some items may cost Embers. The squad decides together who carries what.

When loadouts are set the mission begins.

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

ROLLING FOR SCARS

Scars are **permanent**. They cannot be removed or healed but they are **not punishments**, they are changes. Some may make certain things harder while some open up new ways to operate. Some are just there, part of who the dwarf is now.

- When a dwarf gains a Scar **roll d66**.
- A player may instead choose a scar.
- Write one sentence about how it happened and mark it on your Op sheet.
- If a dwarf rolls a Scar they already have **it deepens**. The GM and player decide together what that means.
- Each dwarf has **3** Scar slots.
- When all 3 are full and a new Scar would be gained, permanently **lose 1 GRIT instead**.

After every mission each surviving dwarf rolls for Scars.

- Roll a d6.
- Add **1 extra d6** for every **GRIT marked** during the mission.
- If any die shows a **1 or 2**, gain 1 Scar.
- Only ever gain 1 Scar per mission regardless of how many dice show 1-2.
- If playing a **one-shot**, roll a scar when the character is created.

GRIT MARKED	DICE ROLLED
0	1d6
1	2d6
2	3d6
3	4d6

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

SCAR TABLE: II-26

THE BODY & THE SENSES

11. MISSING FINGER

One less finger than before, no mechanical effect. You occasionally notice folks notice it.

12. BURN SCARRING

Significant burns across part of the body. Once per mission when taking a clean hit from fire or explosive damage, treat it as Maimed. You've looked into the flames and you're not afraid anymore.

13. CHRONIC PAIN

Something healed wrong, it flares unpredictably. Once per mission, the GM may add +2 to one of your standard action FUSE results. The dwarf knows it's coming and they push through.

15. LIMP

Movement is different now, but you get around all the same. No mechanical effect unless a Hammer or environmental condition specifically affects movement.

14. MISSING EYE

Depth perception is gone, range and fine detail are harder to judge. Precise or ranged actions can never benefit from Squad Aftermath. The dwarf has learned to compensate in other ways.

16. TREMOR

One hand shakes under certain conditions. After assigning a FUSE of 5+, your next CMP roll is stepped down to d4 as you focus to work through it.

21. PARTIAL HEARING LOSS

Explosions have caused you to lose hearing. What you do hear, you trust completely. Once per mission, ignore a GM move that relies on sound.

22. TINNITUS

Constant ringing, it never stops, you have learned to work through it. No mechanical effect. It's just always there.

23. TUNNEL VISION

Peripheral vision narrowed after a close blast. You see what you focus on with complete clarity. Once per mission, ask the GM one specific detail about what you're directly looking at.

24. SENSITIVITY TO LIGHT

Your eyes have taken damage. Torches, flares and exposed forge light cause brief difficulty. In darkness you sees better than most. You may reroll all CMP rolls once in low light conditions.

25. PHANTOM LIMB

A limb is gone, a prosthetic or adapted technique may replace it. You have found ways to operate that others have not considered. Work with the GM to define one thing the adaptation does that an uninjured dwarf cannot.

26. SMELL GONE

You cannot smell anything. Gas traps, chemical agents and fire do not register early. You are immune to any mechanics that rely on scent.

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

SCAR TABLE: 31-46

THE MIND & THE REPUTATION

31. NIGHTMARES

Something from a mission follows you into sleep, it does not affect the job. Between missions the GM may ask you what you dreamt about.

32. HYPERVIGILANCE

The dwarf does not fully switch off, ever. You cannot be ambushed. The first time the GM makes a move against you this Beat, if you haven't moved they discard 1 Aftermath dice first.

33. EMOTIONLESS

Something went quiet inside after the last mission. Social interactions feel different to those around you. Your BLAST never marks Tension.

34. INTRUSIVE MEMORY

A specific moment replays without warning and you have learned to use it. Once per mission when facing a situation similar to the memory, you may reroll your CMP die once.

35. CLAUSTROPHOBIA

Tight spaces trigger a physical response but you try to manage it. In confined spaces, your CMP becomes d8 as you lose your composure.

36. SURVIVOR GUILT

(Reroll this if the squad all survived.) Someone did not make it back and you did. Once per mission when an ally is attacked, you may act immediately outside of normal turn order to reach them.

41. KNOWN FACE

You've been noticed. In locations where the faction has intel on ANVIL, this dwarf raises Heat by an additional +1 on a BLAST of 5 or 6.

42. BURNED CONTACT

A relationship outside the Overhold went wrong during a mission. One downtime action costs 1 additional Ember for the rest of the campaign. Decide with the GM which one and why.

43. MARKED BY THE DEEP

Something from below the craters marked you. Deepbeasts treat you differently. Roll a d6, on 1-3 they always begin friendly to you, on 4-6, hostile.

44. RUMORED DEAD

Word got out that you didn't make it, maybe useful in some situations. Once per mission you may approach an NPC as a complete unknown regardless of Squad Reputation.

45. MARKED FOR DEATH

Someone during the mission made note of you and placed a bounty. Regardless of Squad Rep, enemy factions always recognize you.

46. UNWANTED ATTENTION

Someone outside ANVIL has taken an interest in you specifically, looking to turn you into a Sleeper Agent inside ANVIL.

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

SCAR TABLE: 51-66

THE CRAFT & THE MARKS

51. SHAKY ON EXPLOSIVES

A close call with a bad fuse, you'll still do the work.

IMP results of 6 on Explosive actions count as 4 instead.

52. CRACKED GRIP

Your dominant hand does not close fully anymore. The grip is still there but CMP standard actions can never be rerolled.

53. OVERCAUTIOUS

You check everything twice now. Twice now. You've not missed a trap since. Once per mission automatically detect one hidden threat before it triggers.

54. RECKLESS

Something broke in you, you've stopped calculating the odds. During White Hot and above Heat, you may reroll both CMP and IMP dice and keep the new results.

55. INSTITUTIONAL MEMORY

You've seen enough missions that patterns begin to emerge. Once per mission ask the GM whether a situation resembles something in ANVIL's history and get the answer.

56. METHOD

You've developed a specific way of doing things. Define a specific operational method. Once per mission when acting within that method, FUSE results of 5+ may count as 3.

61. THE AFTERSHAKES

When the mission ends and extraction is complete your hands do not stop shaking for hours. No mechanical effect, other dwarves recognize it.

62. RITUAL

You've developed a specific pre-mission ritual. If the ritual is completed, gain 1 Squad Aftermath dice at mission start. If interrupted or skipped, step CMP die up to d8 for the mission as you don't feel as calm as you should.

63. CALLUSED

You've stopped reacting to things that used to register. Intimidation, horror and morale effects do not apply to you. NPCs notice the ice in your veins.

64. MEMORIAL INK

You got a tattoo after the mission. No mechanical effect. When a dwarf dies or retires, you may add to it by updating the description. It becomes a record of your loss.

65. THE WEIGHT

You carry something from the mission. An object, a name, a promise. Define it and write it down.

66. STILL STANDING

You survived something that should have finished you. Once per mission if you would mark your final GRIT, continue on 1 GRIT instead.

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

OVERHOLD ACTIONS

Each dwarf may take **up to 2 actions** during downtime.
No dwarf may take the **same action twice**.

These base costs apply at Rep tier 3.
Rep modifies all costs:

- Tier 1 adds +2
- Tier 2 adds +1
- Tier 4 subtracts -1
- Tier 5 subtracts -2.

Minimum cost is always 1 Ember.
Actions marked with no cost never require Embers.

ACTION	BASE COST
Memorialize	–
Release Steam	1 Ember
Interrogate	1 Ember
Share Hearth	1 Ember
Fortify	2 Ember
Reinforce	2 Ember
Pull Strings	3 Ember
Scout	1–3 Ember
Forge	3 Ember

Memorialize always costs 0. It cost the squad something, just not Ember.

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

OVERHOLD ACTIONS

MEMORIALIZE (0 EMBER)

Honor the dead and retired.

The dwarf formally adds an anvil to the Overhold’s memorial chamber for fallen or retired operative. Memorialized operatives permanently affect the Overhold in small ways: a name on a plaque, a runeaxe mounted above the forge, their methods taught to new recruits.

- Increase or decrease Squad Rep by 1 mark.
- May unlock a one time benefit tied to what that dwarf was known for.

RELEASE STEAM (1 EMBER)

Drink deep, talk loud, decompress.

Dwarven decompression. The dwarf spends time in the Overhold’s lower halls, drinking, brawling, relaxing.

- Clear all marks on a skill.
- May generate a rumor. Ask the GM one question during briefing.

INTERROGATE (1 EMBER)

Extract intel from prisoners or artifacts.

The dwarf works on a mission asset: a captured enemy, a recovered document, a strange relic. Generates specific actionable intel or reveals lore about enemy factions.

SHARE HEARTH (1 EMBER)

Around shared flame, squads become kin.

You take time to bond with your squad. Describe how you bond with your squad then fill 1 mark on your Bond track.

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

OVERHOLD ACTIONS

FORTIFY (2 EMBER)

Train or study to fortify a skill.

The dwarf fortifies one skill of their choice using the advancement rules. Fortifications should evolve the skill's doctrine, not replace its identity.

When fortifying a skill:

- Choose a Fortification.
- Alter its Creed slightly to reflect what you have learned. Usually this means adding or replacing a single word or two.
- Discuss the mechanical skill change with the GM.
- Mark the skill with the symbol of the Fortification taken in the right side boxes on your Op sheet.

A skill may only be fortified 3 times and cannot take the same Fortification more than once.

- **Extend (-):** Applies to additional dwarves.
- **Deepen (≡):** Triggers in another situation or context.
- **Sharpen (x):** Becomes more reliable, efficient or decisive.
- **Linger (..):** Persists into the next Beat or action.
- **Bend (-):** Adds one exception to a core rule, once per mission.
- **Survive (∧):** A fourth skill mark can be added by circumstance.

You can find Fortify examples at the end of this section.

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

OVERHOLD ACTIONS

REINFORCE (2 EMBER)

Add temporary mission assets.

The dwarf requisitions additional resources for the next mission: a support contact, a safe extraction point, a distraction, a piece of borrowed heavy equipment. These are single use mission assets. Work with the GM to create it.

PULL STRINGS (3 EMBER)

Manipulate Glimmerhold politics.

The dwarf works back channels inside Glimmerhold to shift faction relations, suppress rumors, or reposition ANVIL's political standing.

- May adjust Squad Reputation by 1 mark.
- May affect future mission assignments.

SCOUT (1-3 EMBER)

Reveal mission intel.

The dwarf runs advance reconnaissance on a potential mission target. Reveals one piece of hidden mission intel per ember.

Ex: layout, Temper of key enemies, Hammer thresholds, faction presence, or extraction complications.

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

OVERHOLD ACTIONS

FORGE (3 EMBER)

Craft specialized gear.

The dwarf works with the Overhold’s armourers to upgrade their Runeaxe or Explosives Kit.

A Runeaxe’s blade and rune may be upgraded once.

THE BLADE (D6)

D6	NAME	DETAIL
1	Cold-Forged	The metal never warms. Heat based effects can only Maim this axe.
2	Double Sided	CMP die can be rerolled once for Standard actions.
3	Notched History	When you target an enemy and Botch, the next BLAST against them gains +1.
4	Heavy Headed	Treat BLAST results of 5 as 6.
5	Humming Steel	Will vibrate when deepbeasts within one room.
6	Mirror-Sheen	In [DARK] rooms, you can reflect light to see fine detail without a torch.

THE RUNE (D6)

D6	NAME	DETAIL
1	Thirsting	Glowes red in combat. When you fill a mark on this axe, gain 2 squad Aftermath dice.
2	Static	Hair stands on end. Enemies targeted by this axe cannot use Skills to take the hit.
3	Echo	The impact sounds like a mountain cracking. IMP die can be rerolled for Standard Actions.
4	Boulder	Hits with enhanced weight. Once per mission, treat a FUSE 5+ as a 3.
5	Sunder	Designed for armour. Enemy Temper of 5 or higher is reduced by 1.
6	Keen	The axe wants to hew. Add +1 to BLAST die when using the Runeaxe.

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

OVERHOLD ACTIONS

FORGE, CONT. (3 EMBER)

Craft specialized gear.

An Explosive Kit’s Mix and Casing can be upgraded once.

THE MIX (D6)

D6	NAME	DETAIL
1	Volatile Batch	Sensitive to impact. FUSE of 1-2 doubles your BLAST value.
2	Fine-Grain	Burn is fast and clean. Explosive actions with FUSE 1-2 do not raise Heat.
3	Depth-Salted	Mixed with crater dust. 6s on ExD explode twice.
4	Sticky Residue	The blast clings. These explosives stick to surfaces.
5	Acrid Smoke	Thick, black clouds. After an explosion, the room becomes [DARK] for 3 Beats.
6	Low-Yield	Quiet but precise. Explosions only raise Heat on a BLAST of 6, but max ExD is 3.

THE CASING (D6)

D6	NAME	DETAIL
1	Shrapnel-Packed	Filled with slag. ExD explode on 5 or 6.
2	Magnetized	Sticks to iron. May reroll FUSE roll when blowing up metal.
3	Waterproof Seal	Can be used underwater or in [FLOOD] environments.
4	Timer-Rigged	Reliable clockwork. Treat FUSE results of 1 or 6 as any value.
5	Flash-Bang	Designed to stun. Hits do not become Aftermath dice.
6	Oversized Primers	Big sparks. If an explosion kills an enemy, the Heat track drops by 1.

You may reforge upgrades to replace an existing upgrade. This costs 3 Ember as normal.

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

OVERHOLD ACTIONS

FORTIFY EXAMPLES

ASHCLOAK, BASE

"I leave no trace, make no sound."

Smother triggers on 1-1 or 1-2.

> ASHCLOAK, SHARPEN

"I **always** leave no trace, make no sound."

Smother triggers on 1-1, 1-2 **or** 2-2.

CONTROLLED BURN, BASE

"I contain fire and use it."

Assigning explosive BLAST 6 gives 1 Squad Aftermath.

> CONTROLLED BURN, LINGER

"I contain fire and **keep using** it."

Assigning explosive BLAST 6 gives 1 Squad Aftermath. **Your next explosive action gains +1 BLAST.**

> CONTROLLED BURN, DEEPEN

"I contain **unstable** fire and use it."

Assigning explosive BLAST **5-6** gives 1 Squad Aftermath.

TUNNEL SENSE, BASE

"I hear things coming."

Once per mission, after the GM declares an Aftermath move, may act before it resolves.

> TUNNEL SENSE, BEND

"I hear things **before they happen.**"

Once per mission, after the GM declares **a Hammer**, may act before it resolves.

WHITE IRONS, BASE

"I have been here before and walked out."

Once per mission, treat a clean hit to GRIT as a maim instead.

> WHITE IRONS, SURVIVE

"I have been here before and **barely** walked out."

Once per mission, **fill the 4th mark on this skill instead of taking a clean hit to GRIT.**

SACRIFICIAL RIGGING, BASE

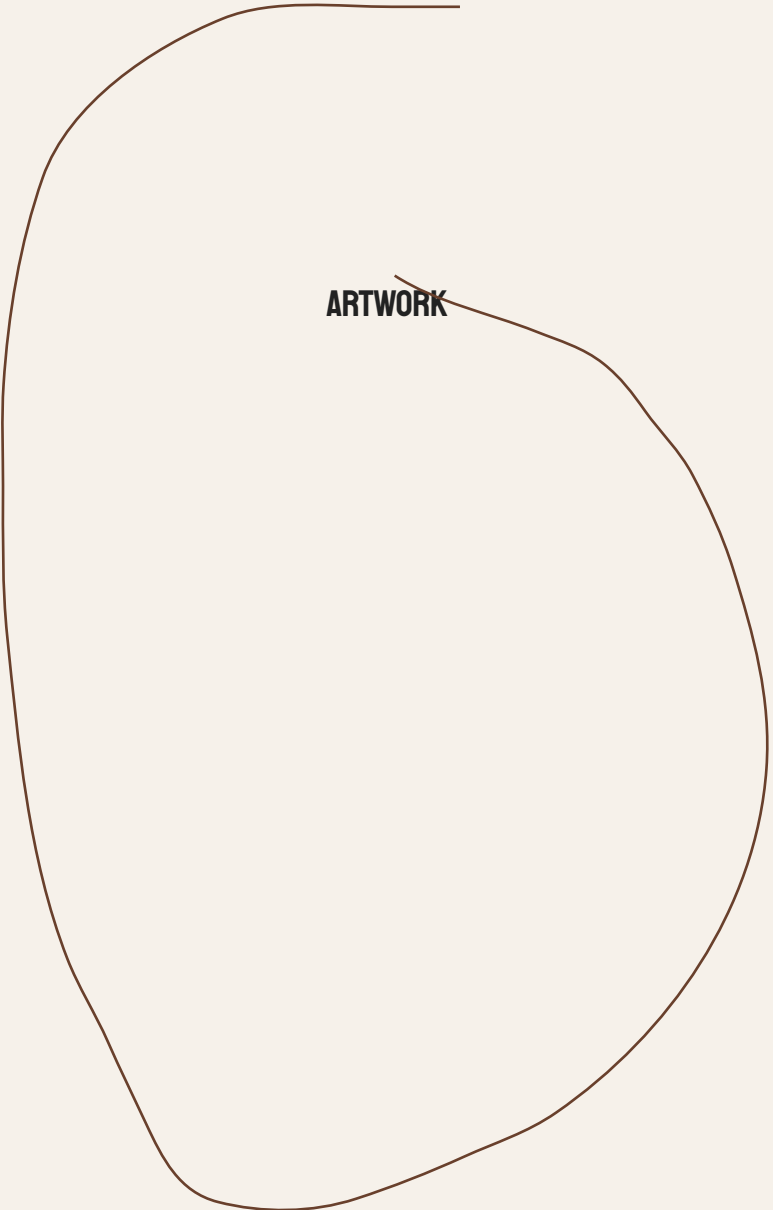
"I know what's worth burning."

Destroy a piece of gear to reduce Heat by 2.

> SACRIFICIAL RIGGING, EXTEND

"I know what's worth **all of us** burning."

You or another dwarf may destroy a piece of gear to reduce Heat by 2.



ARTWORK

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

SQUAD REPUTATION

The GM tracks Squad Reputation on a campaign length track. Reputation reflects how **ANVIL**'s handlers, rivals and enemies perceive the squad. Reputation is not a measure of skill, it is a measure of tactics.

A squad at Myth leaves absolutely nothing behind, no witnesses, no evidence, no name. A squad at Legend gets the job done but the job echoes out.

Reputation is tracked across **25 marks** divided into five tiers of 5. Marks advance or fall based on the Heat level missions end at. Start your campaign at Known[1].

- **Cold:** -2 Rep
- **Warm:** -1 Rep
- **Hot:** No change
- **White Hot:** +1 Rep
- **Shatterpoint:** +2 Rep

SQUAD REPUTATION

1 — MYTH

2 — GHOST

3 — KNOWN

4 — FEARED

5 — LEGEND

EMBER VAULT

UNAVAILABLE

- Rep never goes above tier 5 or below tier 1.
- Marks within a tier have no individual effect.
- When marks would advance or drop past a tier, move to the next tier and continue filling or removing marks.

DOWNTIME & THE OVERHOLD

REP TIER EFFECTS

1 - MYTH

The squad leaves no trace. Missions resolve without rumour, without evidence and without a name attached. The Overhold is unsure if they can be trusted fully. **All Overhold Action costs +2 Embers.** The upside is absolute: no enemy faction knows the squad exists, **no one is preparing and no one is watching.** The squad operates in complete shadow.

2 - GHOST

The squad is starting to be felt without being seen. **All Overhold Actions costs +1 Ember.** There is low chatter in hostile networks. The squad is a pattern enemies have noticed but cannot explain.

3 - KNOWN

The squad has a name, they may not have chosen it but their enemies know it. **Base Overhold Action costs apply.** Factions with good intel networks know **ANVIL** exists. They do not know the squad but they have started paying attention.

4 - FEARED

The squad does not go unnoticed anymore. The Hand gives them priority. **All Overhold Action costs -1 Ember** (minimum 1). The squad may call in one favour per campaign. **Enemies have started preparing specifically for them.**

5 - LEGEND

The squad's reputation arrives before they do. Full Overhold backing. **All Overhold Action costs -2 Embers** (minimum 1). The stash is deep, the Queen's Hand takes personal interest in their survival. **Every faction is running counter intel, placing bounties and briefing their best people.** Some enemies will break and run, others will bring everything they have.

OVERHOLD GEAR STASH & LOOT

OBTAINING GEAR

In the following pages you'll find tables for gear and loot. Dwarves can spend Ember to add gear to their gear slots for the upcoming missions.

Gear remains in your inventory, through missions, until destroyed.

A dwarf may exchange gear for a new piece of gear, the old gear is discarded.

3 cost items should be locked unless a squad is at Legend tier.

ITEM TAGS

[E] Explosive: if struck by outside force roll d6 then that many Explosive dice

[B] Bulk: takes up 2 item slots

[Q] Quiet: BLAST does not raise Heat

[F] Fragile: consumed/destroyed when any mark filled

[~] Consumable: fill a mark each time it is used

[V] Volatile: functions as 1 Explosion die if destroyed

OVERHOLD GEAR STASH & LOOT

STASH GEAR

Weapons, armour and explosives.

WEAPONS & TOOLS

ITEM	TAGS	EFFECT	SLOTS	COST
Runeaxe	-	ANVIL issued. Raises CMP to d6. Can only acquire if destroyed.	-	4
Throwing knives	[~][Q]	Ranged. D4 CMP die.	1	-
Pry bar	-	Treat sealed doors as Temper -2. If used as a weapon: d4 IMP die.	1	-
Grapple and line	[B]	Enables vertical movement.	2	1
Blast shield	[B]	While held, T+1[+].	2	1
Field kit	[~]	Clear 1 mark from a piece of gear	1	1
Stim flask	[~]	Treat CMP as d4 for one roll. Cannot stack.	1	1
Crossbow	[~]	Ranged. D8 IMP die.	1	2
Med stout	[~]	Roll a d6, on a 4+ restore 1 GRIT.	1	2

ARMOUR & PROTECTION

ITEM	TAGS	EFFECT	SLOTS	COST
Leather jack	-	Base Absorption layer. Adds [+].	1	1
Reinforced leathers	-	Temper +1 against standard attacks.	1	1
Dampening wrap	[F]	BLAST raises Heat on 5+ instead of 4+.	1	1
Blast coat	[B]	Explosive damage clean hits become maims.	2	2
Mithril plate	[B]	Temper +2. Environmental clean hits become maims.	2	3

OVERHOLD GEAR STASH & LOOT

STASH GEAR

EXPLOSIVES

ITEM	TAGS	EFFECT	COST
Explosives Kit	[E]	ANVIL issued. Raises IMP to d6. Infinite small charges. Can only acquire if destroyed.	4
Powder train	[~][E][V]	A length of slow fuse connected to any explosive. Placing and add +2 to FUSE for Explosive action. Can be cut.	1
Satchel charge	[~][E]	Each mark filled adds +1 Explosive dice to the pool.	1
Flashpot	[~][E][Q]	Only affects living targets. d4 IMP die.	1
Breach pellets	[~][E][Q]	Destroys locks, hinges, etc. Only affects one target point.	1
Smoke Canister	[~][V][Q]	When triggered fills the room with smoke. [DARK] for BLAST value Beats.	1
Burnpack	[~][E]	Incendiary. Each ExD that hits sets a target on fire. Fire deals 1 maim per Beat and adds 1 Aftermath die to the GM pool per Beat until extinguished.	1
Deadman charge	[~][E][F]	Attached to a target. Detonates when triggered. Visible if searched, GM must warn the squad once before an enemy triggers it.	2
Thermite pot	[~]	Slow burn. Deals each Explosion hit over time at one per Beat.	2
Concussion keg	[~][E][B]	No damage. Hits apply stun: Players mark a skill. For 2 Beats GM must discard 1 Aftermath die to make any move.	2
Ricochet charge	[~][E]	In a room with [FORT], ExD explode on 4+.	2
Sapper charges	[~][E][B]	d8 IMP die.	2
Shaped charge	[~][E]	Ignore one [+] of target. Must be placed with FUSE 3 or lower or explodes immediately.	2
Depth charge	[~][E][B][F]	+3 Explosive dice. Each hit counts as 2 vs structures.	3
Cluster keg	[~][E][B]	d12 IMP die.	3

OVERHOLD GEAR STASH & LOOT

STASH ITEMS

Things the squad can requisition with a purpose in mind. Get creative.

WEAPONS & TOOLS

ITEM	TAGS	COST
Rope	-	-
Spool of black thread	[F]	-
Coil of wire	[Q]	-
Length of iron chain	-	-
Torch	[~]	-
Signal flare	[~]	-
Tinderbox and tallow	[~]	-
Lamp oil flask	[~] [V] [E]	-
Large lock	-	-
Shackles	-	-
Chalk	[~] [Q]	-
Dwarf-size sack	[B]	-
Lead weights	[B]	-
Wax seal kit	-	-
Folded uniform	-	-
Fishing net	-	-
Sack of sand	-	-
Iron pot	-	-
Notebook	-	-
Mirror kit	[Q]	1
Snare trap	[~]	1
Forged work order	[F]	1
Pulley and cable	[B]	1

CAMPAIGNS & FACTIONS

RUNNING A CAMPAIGN

A campaign is the full arc of multiple Faction Agendas from first movement to resolution. There is no fixed mission count. A campaign can end when every active Agenda is either completed or dismantled or when the consequences of completed Agendas make further **ANVIL** operations impossible.

Tight Single Faction
~7-10 missions

Two Factions in Conflict
~10-15 missions

Multiple Factions
Long campaign. The squad will not stop all of them.

The Hand assigns missions based on what the squad knows and what the Overhold can confirm.

Between sessions the should GM ask themselves:

- What is each faction doing right now?
- What does the squad know about it?
- What happens if they ignore it for one more mission?

The answers build the next briefing.

CAMPAIGNS & FACTIONS

FACTIONS

Factions are the **active forces** in the world that **ANVIL** is working against. They have **goals**, **resources** and **momentum** of their own. They do not wait for the squad to come to them.

Each faction has an **Agenda**: a five step plan they are executing whether ANVIL intervenes or not.

Each step has **2 marks** to fill. Each step the squad does not disrupt, the faction moves closer to completing it. When a faction reaches step 5 and completes their Agenda, a permanent campaign consequence locks in.

The GM defines each faction's Agenda during campaign prep. Factions do not need to be fully detailed upfront, their Agenda steps and Moves can be built session to session as the campaign develops.

FACTION AGENDAS

Write a short description of what a faction is doing at each step and how the world looks if that step completes unchecked.

STEP 1

Early movement. Quiet, deniable. Easily disrupted.

STEP 2

Establishing. Resources and folks are in place.

STEP 3

Entrenched. Disruption requires a focused mission.

STEP 4

Operational. Bold, exposed, damage accumulating.

STEP 5

Complete, no going back. Campaign consequence locked in.

The squad can only directly engage **one** faction per mission but other factions keep moving while they do.

CAMPAIGNS & FACTIONS

AGENDA ADVANCEMENT

If the squad does not run a mission against a faction, in **between sessions** the GM rolls a d6. On a result matching the Agenda step guide, advance the faction's Agenda one mark. The threshold depends on the faction's current step. Higher steps mean more momentum, a faction that has been left alone is harder to slow down.

KEY FIGURE		TOUR
AGENDA		
1	☐ ☐	
2	☐ ☐	
3	☐ ☐	
4	☐ ☐	
5 COMPLETION		

Step 5 **does not** roll. If the squad does not run a mission to stop it, it completes.

DISRUPTING AGENDAS

Running a mission against a faction can stall their Agenda depending on the outcome.

MISSION RESULT	AGENDA EFFECT
Primary objective completed	Agenda does not advance, no roll.
Primary failed, secondary completed	GM rolls, adding +1 to the roll for each secondary completed.
Mission failed entirely	Agenda advances automatically, no roll.
All objectives completed	Roll back the Agenda one mark. If at Step 1 mark 1, faction dismantled.

CAMPAIGNS & FACTIONS

FACTION MOVES

Between sessions each active faction makes **one Move**. These are actions that reflect their current Agenda step and what happened last mission. The GM chooses the Move that makes the most fictional sense. It is narrated at the start of the next session or woven into the mission briefing. Moves scale with Agenda step.

STEP 1-2 MOVES

- Place an informant or observer near a location the squad frequents
 - Begin acquiring resources, personnel or territory
 - Make contact with a potential ally faction
 - Establish a new site or forward position
-

STEP 3 MOVES

- Fortify a key location the squad will need to enter
 - Begin gathering intel on **ANVIL**'s methods
 - Move a high value asset to a protected position
 - Strike at a peripheral **ANVIL** resource
-

STEP 4-5 MOVES

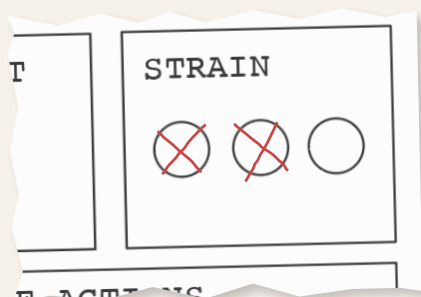
- Place an elite operative or counter-squad in an upcoming mission
- Issue a bounty on a specific dwarf by name
- Strike directly at the Overhold; a burned contact, a compromised safe house, a threat delivered
- Forge an alliance with another faction, combining assets for one mission

A faction at step 4 that successfully targets the Overhold marks **Overhold Strain**.

CAMPAIGNS & FACTIONS

OVERHOLD STRAIN

When factions attack **ANVIL**, the Overhold takes on Strain. The Overhold has **three Strain marks**. Faction Moves that successfully target **ANVIL** mark one Strain.



ONE STRAIN

The Hand is nervous.

No mechanical effect. Briefings get shorter and the stash thins slightly.

TWO STRAIN

One Overhold Action becomes unavailable until Strain clears. The GM decides which one based on what the faction targeted.

THREE STRAIN

The Overhold is compromised. **Two Overhold Actions are unavailable. Rep advancement is frozen** until Strain drops below three.

CLEARING STRAIN

- A successful **Pull Strings** action clears 1 mark.
- Extracting at **Cold to Hot** clears 1 mark.
- Only **one** mark may clear per downtime.

MULTIPLE FACTIONS

Two or three active factions means the squad is constantly triaging. Every downtime they pick one faction to run against and the rest keep moving.

Factions at similar Agenda steps may conflict with each other. When two factions are operating in the same location or competing for the same resource, the GM should drop that conflict into a mission.

A faction Move at step 4-5 can establish an uneasy faction alliance.

CAMPAIGNS & FACTIONS

BUILDING A FACTION

When building a faction, define:

- **Name and nature:** Who they are and what they want.
- **Agenda steps:** What they are doing at each of the five steps.
- **Completion consequence:** What the world looks like if step 5 finishes.
- **Starting step:** Most factions begin at step 1 mark 1.
- **Key Figures:** Any major NPCs of the faction.
- **Tone:** How to roleplay faction members.

EXAMPLE FACTION

Name	The Hollow Choir
Nature	Deep-cult accelerationists
Agenda steps	1: WIP
	2: WIP
	3: WIP
	4: WIP
	5: WIP
Completion	The Wide Gate, titan deepbeasts awoken.
Starting step	2-2 (they have been operating for months before ANVIL notices)
Key figure	Sevran, ritual leader, deeptouched, true believer
Tone	Patient, convinced, increasingly bold

PROCEDURES

BEFORE THE CAMPAIGN

- Create 2-3 active factions.
- Give each faction: a 5-step Agenda, a tone, a key figure, a completion consequence.
- Decide the current state of Glimmerhold.
- Determine what ANVIL is currently worried about.
- Create or expand the Overhold stash. Giving players access to stash items based on their Ember value is the simplest way to run it. Add 2 Ember to the vault for each player so dwarves have Ember to prepare for the first mission.
- Start the campaign with a mission briefing, gear stash requisition and then drop them in.

BEFORE EACH MISSION

- Create the mission sheet.
- Draw the keyed map.
- Assign: entrances, objectives, faction presence, environment tags, Hammer events.
- Decide: what the faction wants right now, what happens if the squad fails, what changes at Hot, White Hot and Shatterpoint.
- Prepare: enemy Temper values, patrol routes, hazards, extraction complications.

DURING BRIEFING

- Explain: the primary objective, known threats, known entrances, Ember payout.
- Reveal Scout intel earned during downtime.
- Answer squad planning questions honestly, roleplay the Hand earnestly.
- Give partial information, not complete certainty.

PROCEDURES

AT MISSION START

- Set: Heat to 0, Beats to 0, GM Aftermath equal to number of players.
- Describe: drop-in, atmosphere, things in the immediate surrounding area.
- Ask: "What do you do?"

DURING PLAY

- Let players act freely.
- Do not rotate initiative.
- Only call for throw stones when: outcome is uncertain, consequences matter, pressure exists.
- Keep the fiction moving forward constantly.

RUNNING AFTERMATH

- Spend Aftermath only when: something directly threatens players, enemies attack, traps activate, hazards escalate.
- Minimum spend is 2 dice.
- Assign FUSE and BLAST exactly like players do.
- Use free moves often: patrols shifting, doors locking, sounds echoing, smoke spreading, lights failing.

RUNNING HEAT

Track Heat openly.

- Raise Heat immediately when triggered.
- Announce Heat stage transitions clearly.
- Hammers are consequences of player actions. Hammers should: change space, change behavior, complicate objectives, force adaptation.
- Never use Hammers as random punishment.

PROCEDURES

RUNNING COMBAT

- Combat is not a mode switch.
- Keep asking: "What are you doing?"
- Enemies should: flank, reposition, ignite explosives, lock routes, call reinforcements, use the environment.
- Avoid stationary slugfests.

RUNNING DOWNTIME

- Slow the pace down.
- Let dwarves breathe.
- Ask questions: "What rumors are spreading?"
"Who are you drinking with?"
"What does the funeral look like?"
"Who is avoiding eye contact?"
- Let politics and relationships matter.
- Check if Overhold Strain clears.

BETWEEN MISSIONS

- Advance faction Agendas.
- Make faction Moves.
- Update: Overhold Strain, Reputation, stash access.
- Ask: "What changed because of the last mission?"

ADVICE & TIPS

KEEP THINGS MOVING

ANVIL works best when the world never feels static. Doors close. Patrols move. Smoke spreads. Fires grow. People react. Even silence should feel active. "Everything has become still."

TREAT MISSIONS LIKE COLLAPSES

The mission should slowly lose stability as Heat rises.

- Cold missions feel: tense, surgical, uncertain
- White Hot missions feel: desperate, loud, improvised
- Shatterpoint feels like: survival, escape, disaster containment

The mission should transform over time.

USE FREE MOVES CONSTANTLY

Free moves bring the world to life. Use them to: foreshadow danger, reveal consequences, build pressure, reposition enemies. Do not wait for players to fail rolls before changing the environment.

HAMMERS MUST CHANGE THE SITUATION

A Hammer should never just mean "more guards appear." Instead: exits seal, floodgates open, a target relocates, the foundry activates, prisoners riot, rival factions arrive, deepbeasts awaken. A Hammer should force adaptation.

LET PLAYERS BE COMPETENT

ANVIL operatives are elite. Do not make players roll for things like basic climbing, obvious observations, simple movement. Roll when: timing matters, consequences matter, pressure exists.

ADVICE & TIPS

ASK OPERATIONAL QUESTIONS

Good ANVIL GMing sounds like: "How are you doing that?" / "What are you doing while this happens?" / "Who is watching the rear?" / "What is your extraction plan now?" / "What does your attack look like?"

PRESSURE IS BETTER THAN PUNISHMENT

The game works best when consequences escalate naturally. Players should feel: cornered, rushed, exposed, overwhelmed, without feeling arbitrarily punished. The world reacts because of what they're doing.

MAKE THE OVERHOLD MATTER

The Overhold is not just a menu screen. It should feel: heavy, political, tired, haunted. Operatives should: mourn people, argue about tactics, drink together, avoid each other, gossip, prepare, crack under strain. Downtime is emotional decompression.

FACTIONS SHOULD REMEMBER THINGS

A faction should evolve based on: who survived, what exploded, what was stolen, what Heat level extraction hit, which operatives were seen. The world should accumulate operational history.

PLAY TO THE DWARVES

ANVIL is not heroic fantasy. It is: industrial, militant, dirty, loud, ritualistic. The squad are not adventurers. They are professional operational wrecking crews sent into impossible places. Treat them like veterans.

ENEMIES AND THREATS

READING THE STATBLOCK

Every threat on the Classified Threat Log sheet communicates the same core information about an enemy.

- **Name:** is the threat's name, either their role (Guard, Elite Guard) or a proper name for important enemies and bosses. Named threats always have at least 1 skill.
- **Temper:** is the single most important part of the statblock. It tells you two things at once: the BLAST threshold required to affect the target or the number of explosive hits (the [+] brackets) needed to destroy them outright. A T4[++] target cannot be scratched by a BLAST of 3 or less, needs a BLAST of 4 to Maim and requires two Explosion die hits to destroy.
- **GRIT:** is tracked by the solid circles. Enemies work exactly like dwarves, Maim marks one circle, a clean hit fills GRIT.
- **Skills:** are the threat's tactical abilities. Non-boss enemies have one or no skills. Boss level threats have two skills.
- **Gear:** represents the enemies entire kit. GMs can mark gear to take a hit but each mark isn't tied to specific gear. Generally a GM will want to mark skills before gear to not lose access to a threats attacks. If a threat loses all it's gear it will flee or surrender.

The tips and guidelines in this section reference the statblocks in the **attached FROZEN SIGNAL mission document**.

ENEMIES AND THREATS

THREAT TIERS

Build enemies around Temper. Temper is the table's shorthand for how dangerous and durable a threat is.

- **T2:** Unarmored, quick to drop. Standard threats. A dwarf with a clean axe swing will cut through these without trouble.
- **T3:** The baseline. A soldier in chainmail, a competent guard, beasts. Requires a solid BLAST to handle cleanly.
- **T4:** Hardened. Elite soldiers, veteran operatives, heavily plated threats. Multiple marks and often a meaningful Skill.
- **T5+:** Reserved for boss level threats, dangerous creatures, and objects that are meant to anchor a room. Temper 5 with brackets means the squad needs explosives or a coordinated Stack Up.

Explosive brackets tell you how many dedicated Explosion die hits are needed before a threat is destroyed. Build your bosses with at least [++] if you want them to last.

BUILDING A STANDARD THREAT

A standard threat needs:

1. A name or role.
2. A Temper value (no brackets for disposable, two brackets for tougher).
3. None or one skill.
4. Gear appropriate to their role.

Keep Skills focused. The best standard Skills do one of three things: modify how the threat interacts with BLAST and FUSE, generate Aftermath dice, or restrict what the dwarves can do. Skills that do all three at once belong on bosses.

ENEMIES AND THREATS

Good standard skill practice: One reactive Skill (triggers when something happens, a hit, a missed attack, an ally being nearby) and one proactive Skill (ongoing condition or action it can take each Beat).

Operative Bobcat from FROZEN SIGNAL is a good example. One Skill forces a dwarf to reassign their BLAST die before acting. The other adds Heat if Bobcat marks no GRIT. Both are simple, both create decisions and neither requires remembering complex triggers.

BUILDING A BOSS THREAT

Boss threats have two meaningful skills and a Temper with multiple brackets. They are meant to be memorable encounters, not just hard ones.

Design bosses around a gimmick the players have to solve rather than raw durability. The gimmick is the Skill set and the environment.

Examples from FROZEN SIGNAL:

- Operative Raptor adds 1 Heat every Beat any dwarf is in his room without cover. This isn't a combat skill, it's a skill that punishes bad positioning and forces the squad to think about where they stand, not just whether they hit.
- Highcroft adds 2ExD to all attacks when first reduced to 0 GRIT. The squad has to decide whether to commit to finishing him in one coordinated action or deal with an enraged second phase. He also blocks the Core objective while alive, tying the boss fight to the mission goal directly.
- Mithril Gear Golem cannot be damaged until its sensor is destroyed. It's a puzzle disguised as combat. Hits redirect to a separate target.

ENEMIES AND THREATS

A strong boss has:

- A defensive Skill that creates a requirement (must destroy X first, must be in cover, must spend Aftermath).
- An offensive Skill that complicates an action the squad will be tempted to do.
- Gear that absorbs hits and changes the flavor of the fight.

DESIGNING GEAR FOR THREATS

Enemy Gear works like dwarf Gear. Three marks, absorbs hits, depletes. Use Gear to tell the story of the threat before the fight begins.

- Chainmail, Shortsword, Crossbow: Generic guard. Threat at range, threat up close.
- Blastmail, Battleaxe, Throwing Knives: Elite aggressor. Blastmail signals explosive resistance before the squad even rolls.
- Siege Cannon, Heavy Plate: Slow and heavily fortified. Needs to be repositioned or shut down before the dwarves can work freely.
- Glyphic Greatsword, Command Armour: The Armour suggests high Temper. The Greatsword signals high BLAST output. Both pieces signal to the players to not trade hits with this one.

Name the Gear with intent. Players hear Gear lines the same way they hear room descriptions, it tells them what kind of fight this is going to be before dice are rolled.

ARTWORK

MISSION GENERATION TABLES

Start with location and objective. These two together tell you what the space looks like and what the squad needs to do. Add faction and complication before you draw the map. The complication should shape where rooms need to go and what they need to contain.

Write Hammer events after the map is drawn. Walk through the rooms and ask: if the squad has been here for 15 Beats and made a lot of noise what has changed? That answer is your Hot Hammer, scale up from there.

Drop room features in after keying. Five to eight features for a ten room map is plenty.

ROLL IN ORDER

STEP	ROLL	DETERMINES	NOTES
1	d20	Location type	Name it and give one sentence of atmosphere.
2	d8	Objective type	Write the primary success condition.
3	2d6	Faction type	Write their Cold and Shatterpoint behavior first and fill the middle later.
4	2d6	Complication	This is your pressure valve, it changes how the primary objective plays out.
5	d6 x3	Hammer seeds	One per tier. Finish each as a concrete event for your location.
6	d20 x3-5	Room features	Scatter across your map, not every room needs one.

A full mission can be generated quickly with this sequence. The tables give you seeds, then let the fiction you already know about your factions, location and campaign makes them specific to your table.

MISSION GENERATION TABLES

LOCATION - D20	
ROLL	LOCATION
1	Name it and give one sentence of atmosphere.
2	Active mine
3	Noble estate
4	River barge in transit
5	Ruined revealed by craters
6	Active military outpost
7	Underground compound network
8	Forest logging camp
9	Cliffside compound
10	Informal settlement
11	Mountain pass garrison
12	Underground cult shrine
13	Glimmerhold sewer junctions
14	Watchtower network
15	Ruined dam
16	Black market warehouse cluster
17	Decommissioned relay station network
18	Deepbeast nesting site
19	Active harbour
20	Flooded quarry

MISSION GENERATION TABLES

OBJECTIVE - D8		
D8	TYPE	PRIMARY SUCCESS
1	Extraction	The target leaves with the squad.
2	Elimination	Confirmed removal of a specific target.
3	Sabotage	The thing no longer functions.
4	Recovery	The object leaves intact.
5	Surveillance	Leave with the intel undetected.
6	Interruption	The event never occurs.
7	Escort	The target is delivered alive.
8	Infiltration	Zero trace. Cold or Warm extraction required.

Secondary objectives should never be required to complete the primary. Primary objectives can be required to complete secondaries.

MISSION GENERATION TABLES

FACTION - 2D6	
2D6	FACTION
2	Defector soldiers. Disciplined and well equipped.
3	Mercenary company. Professional and motivated by pay.
4	Noble house guards. Loyal to a specific lord.
5	Deep cult cell. Zealous and erratic.
6	Criminal syndicate. Smart and lightly armed.
7	Corrupt city watch inspectors. Armed with authority and bribes.
8	Salvage crew with hired muscle.
9	Rogue deepbeast handlers. Working to control deepbeasts.
10	Hidden order or society. Nobody fully knows their goals.
11	Arcane research team with private security. The researchers are the real threat.
12	Two factions already in conflict. Roll twice. The squad arrives mid fight.
Write faction behavior at each Heat stage as one sentence. Cold is normal operations. Shatterpoint is total breakdown.	

MISSION GENERATION TABLES

COMPLICATION - 2D6	
2D6	COMPLICATION
2	The primary objective has already been partially completed by someone else.
3	A civilian is embedded with the faction and cannot be ignored.
4	One entrance from the briefing is already sealed or compromised on arrival.
5	The objective is time sensitive. It degrades, leaves or activates within 10-15 Beats.
6	A secondary faction arrives, uninvited and with their own agenda.
7	The primary objective requires something the squad wasn't told to bring.
8	The location is structurally unstable. Every [E] of 4-6 risks a collapse.
9	The target is aware ANVIL is coming. Not when or how but aware.
10	The primary objective splits. Two locations and one extraction window.
11	The extraction route requires passing back through the hottest room.
12	Completing the primary directly enables a faction's next Agenda step.

The complication changes how the primary plays out, it shouldn't replace it.

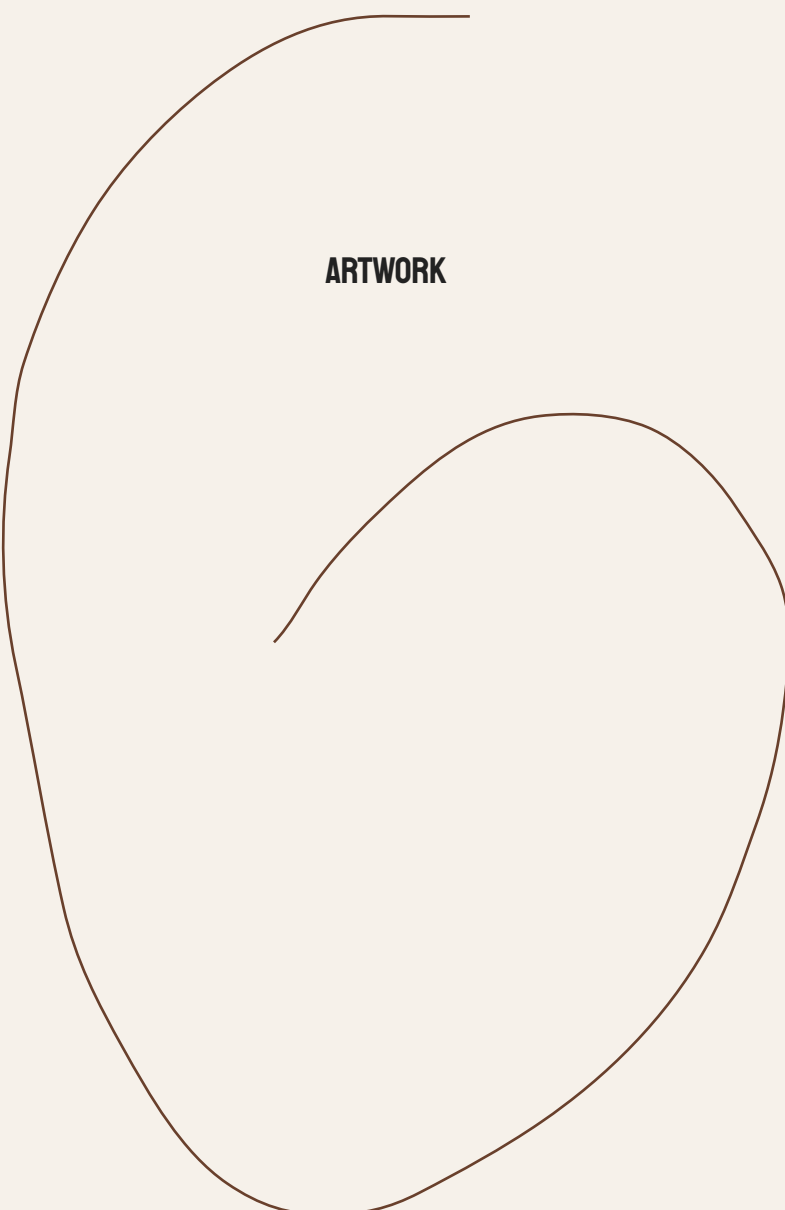
MISSION GENERATION TABLES

HAMMER SEEDS

Roll d6 once per threshold. The seed gives you the type of escalation then you can finish the event for your specific location and faction.

HAMMER SEEDS	
HOT (11-15) - D6	
D6	SEED
1	A route between two rooms seals, permanently or until cleared.
2	The faction goes to full alert, patrols double up.
3	A secondary objective becomes unreachable without a confrontation.
4	An NPC the squad has been avoiding is now directly in their path.
5	An environment tag activates in a room the squad hasn't entered yet.
6	The faction calls for outside support, it arrives in 6 Beats.
WHITE HOT (16-19) - D6	
D6	SEED
1	The primary objective changes state; it moves, locks or starts degrading.
2	A named elite NPC enters the map at the worst possible point.
3	Two rooms become inaccessible simultaneously.
4	The faction begins actively destroying the objective rather than protecting it.
5	Every remaining enemy on the map converges on the squad's last known position.
6	A deepbeast responds to arcane discharge, it hasn't attacked yet.
SHATTERPOINT (20+) - D6	
D6	SEED
1	The location begins full structural collapse. Every few beats rooms crumble. [E] now affects adjacent rooms.
2	All exits except one are sealed. The remaining exit is guarded by a difficult enemy.
3	A large deepbeast enters the map. It's everyone's problem.
4	The objective is now at the extraction point, this is the faction's last stand.
5	The location floods, burns or begins venting. Every Beat costs something.
6	The faction's most dangerous asset is released and pointed at the squad.

ARTWORK



MISSION GENERATION TABLES

ROOM FEATURES - D20	
D20	FEATURE
1	A wall-mounted rack of tools, weapons or equipment. One piece is missing.
2	A locked chest or strongbox. The key is on an npc.
3	A window, shaft or hole looking into an adjacent room.
4	A collapsed section of floor. Drop is 20 feet into the room below.
5	A pile of ledgers, manifests or logbooks.
6	A barricade hastily built by whoever was here last.
7	A prisoner, alone and alive.
8	A mechanism that controls something in an adjacent room.
9	Signs of a very recent fight.
10	A faction banner, insignia or mark that does not belong to the current occupants.
11	A body, days old, their gear is intact.
12	A load-bearing column or support beam. Destroying it affects the room above or below
13	A working fireplace, forge or furnace. The embers still glow.
14	A hidden alcove or false wall.
15	A message scratched into the wall at dwarf-height.
16	A guard post with a sightline to two other rooms.
17	A stockpile of supplies for the faction.
18	A deepbeast mark, jagged scarring on the walls, fresh.
19	An NPC with nothing to do with the mission.
20	The room is exactly as the briefing described it.

RULES FOR THE GRID

WARNING: Everything in this section applies only when playing with miniatures and terrain. If you're playing theatre of the mind, ignore this section.

MOVEMENT

All dwarves move 5 squares per turn. When moving carefully, be it stealth, cautious advance, avoiding a patrol; reduce movement by your assigned FUSE result.

ie: FUSE 3 while sneaking: move 2 squares.

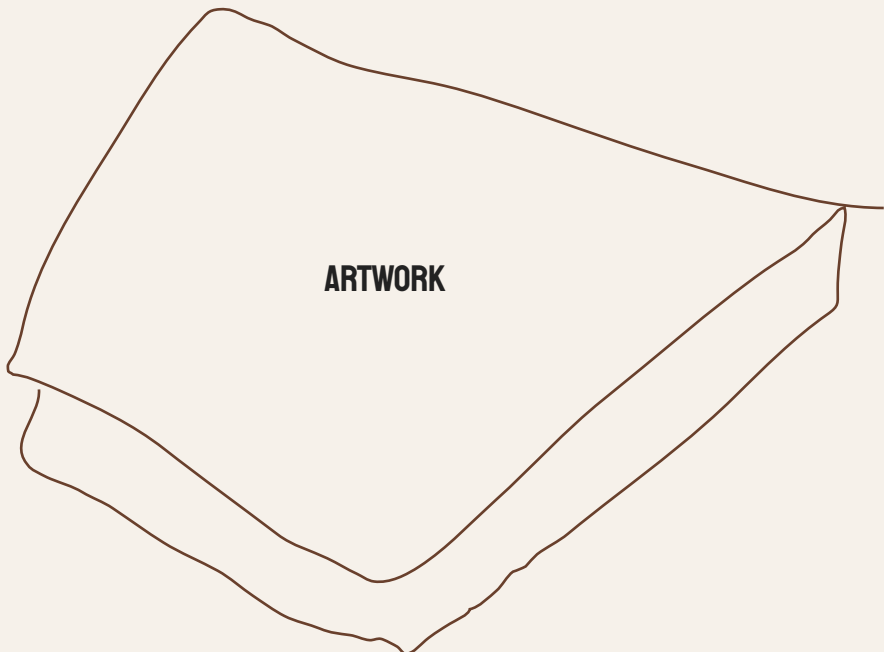
Encumbrance applies as normal on top of this.

ADJACENCY

Any rule referencing adjacency; Stack Up, Rune Bracing, Bond redirects, means within 1 square in any direction.

RANGE

Actions with a range component use base range minus FUSE. Low FUSE means faster, tighter execution. High FUSE means the action took longer, covered less ground, or landed short.



RULES FOR THE GRID

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BLAST RADIUS & COVER

BLAST RADIUS

Explosions radiate outward from the point of detonation.

SIZE	RADIUS
Small	2 squares
Medium	3 squares
Large	4 squares
Special	5-6 squares

Structures stop blast radius. A structure that takes Explosion Dice hits stops the blast, it doesn't hit things on the other side.

COVER

A target behind a wall, pillar, barricade or solid terrain feature gains: Temper +1, One additional [+].

A dwarf at T3 in cover becomes T4[+]. A dwarf at T3[+] in cover becomes T4[+++].

Line of sight is blocked by terrain, not by miniatures.

RULES FOR THE GRID

WARNING: Everything in this section applies only when playing with miniatures and terrain. If you're playing theatre of the mind, ignore this section.

ENEMY MOVEMENT & HAMMERS

ENEMY MOVEMENT

Enemies move at one of three speeds.

SPEED	SQUARES
Slow	3
Normal	5
Fast	7

Enemy speed is listed on their stat block. If not listed, use Normal.

THE HAMMER ON THE TABLE

Hammers should do something physical. When a Hammer drops, change the table.

- **Add terrain:** barricades go up, a gate drops, rubble falls
- **Remove terrain:** a wall comes down, a bridge collapses, an exit is sealed
- **Change terrain:** a room floods, fire spreads across tiles, lights go out
- **Remove a room:** collapse it entirely, block every exit

Explosions can trigger the same. A BLAST 6 in an [UNSTABLE] room can bring down the whole space.

CHASE ON THE GRID

The chase d6 still runs as written, the die face represents distance. Move the pursuing miniature closer or further on the table to match, rooms and corridors give the chase real geography.

EXAMPLES OF PLAY

EXAMPLE 1: MISSION PLAY

GM: The maintenance tunnel opens into a cramped storage chamber. Torchlight flickers through iron shelving. One guard in chainmail sits half asleep at a table on the far side. Beyond him, black scorch marks streak a reinforced stone wall.

Heat is 3. Aftermath is 4.

GM: What are you doing?

Petra Stonewarden: I want to slip in and kill the guard before he can react.

GM: You can certainly try, how do you do it?

Petra: I'll crouch down and sneak in along the wall, hiding behind the shelving and then take his head off with my axe.

GM: Brutal, clean, efficient, throw stones.

Petra rolls: CMP d6 = 2, IMP d6 = 5

Petra: I'll slam the 2 as FUSE and 5 as BLAST.

GM: Low FUSE, clean execution. BLAST 5 raises Heat by 1. The guard is T3. That's a clean hit.

Petra crosses the room before the guard fully looks up. The runeaxe catches him under the jaw and drives him sideways into the table hard enough to split his head from his body. Heat is at 4. Cold.

Brek Ironmark: Damn.

GM: As the body hits the floor, dust shakes loose from the ceiling above. Somewhere deeper in the foundry you hear boots moving.

Dunvik Forgeback: They're gonna hear us eventually anyway. I want to breach the wall.

GM: With explosives?

Dunvik: Obviously. I'm going to lay a TNT charge at the base of the wall next to this guard's table.

EXAMPLES OF PLAY

EXAMPLE 1: MISSION PLAY

GM: You kick the guard's head to the corner and place a bundle of TNT at the base of the wall, throw stones.

Dunvik's roll: CMP: 6, IMP: 4.

Dunvik: Oh yeah! I'll use 4 as FUSE and 6 as BLAST.

GM: The charge detonates in 4 Beats. Heat rises by 6 immediately to 10. The situation is getting warm.

Dunvik rolls 6 Explosion
Dice: 2, 4, 4, 5, 6, 6

GM: Four hits. Both 6s explode again.

Dunvik rolls: 3, 5

GM: One more hit for a total of five. The wall is T[+++]. You all take cover behind the shelves as the fuse burns down. Sssss, kaBOOOOOM! The dust clears and where there was once a wall lies a giant hole. It's obliterated. I also gain 6 Aftermath dice.

Brek: Oh no.

GM: The your newly created doorway is a furnace chamber glowing orange with molten runoff. Alarm bells immediately begin ringing through the foundry. And somewhere much deeper below you hear something roar back.

EXAMPLES OF PLAY

EXAMPLE 2: DOWNTIME PLAY

GM: You extracted White Hot after collapsing half the excavation site beneath Carrow's Mine. Primary objective succeeded. One secondary failed. Reputation increases by 1 mark. The Hollow Choir does not advance their Agenda.

GM: Recovery time. Brek, you marked 2 GRIT during the mission so roll 3d6 for your Scars.

Brek rolls: 2, 4, 5

GM: You gain a Scar. Roll d66 for me please.

Brek rolls: 32

GM: Hypervigilance.

Brek: Yeah, after that mission that makes sense.

GM: What caused it?

Brek: After the collapse. When I was trapped under the rubble, if I would have just heard those cultists coming I wouldn't have needed saving.

GM: Brek tells himself he's got to stay alert. Write that down.

Petra: I'm going to Release Steam.

GM: What does that look like?

Petra: Drinking in the lower forge halls. Not really talking. Just sitting there sharpening my axe.

GM: You sip a strong dark ale, listening to the chatter or the tables around you. The forge smoke is heavy in the air tonight but that always makes you feel relaxed. Clear the marks on your skill. While you're down there, you overhear a rumor. Someone in Glimmerhold is asking questions about the foundry explosion.

Dunvik: Good luck narrowing that down.

GM: Dunvik?

Dunvik: Forge action. I want to upgrade my Explosives Kit.

GM: Roll on the Casing or Mix table.

EXAMPLES OF PLAY

EXAMPLE 2: DOWNTIME PLAY

Dunvik rolls: 5

GM: Acrid Smoke. Your explosions now turn rooms [DARK] for 3 Beats.

Dunvik Forgeback: Sick.

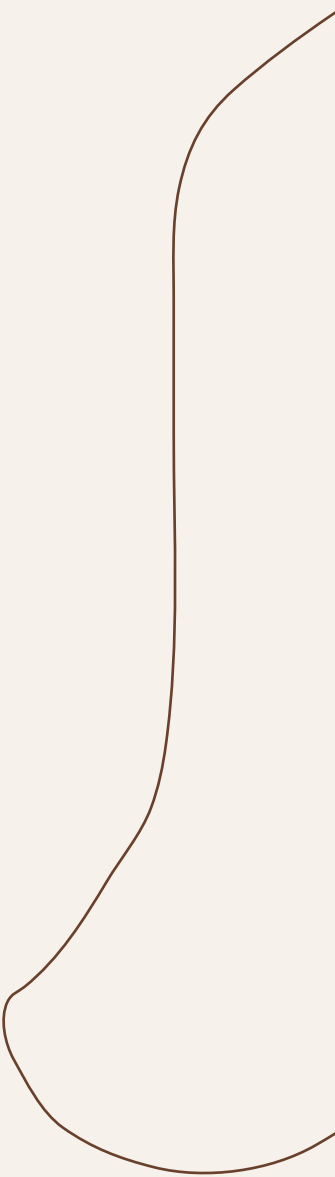
Brek Ironmark: I'm taking Share Hearth with my squad.

GM: What are you doing together?

Brek: Honestly, probably just sitting there in silence after the mission.

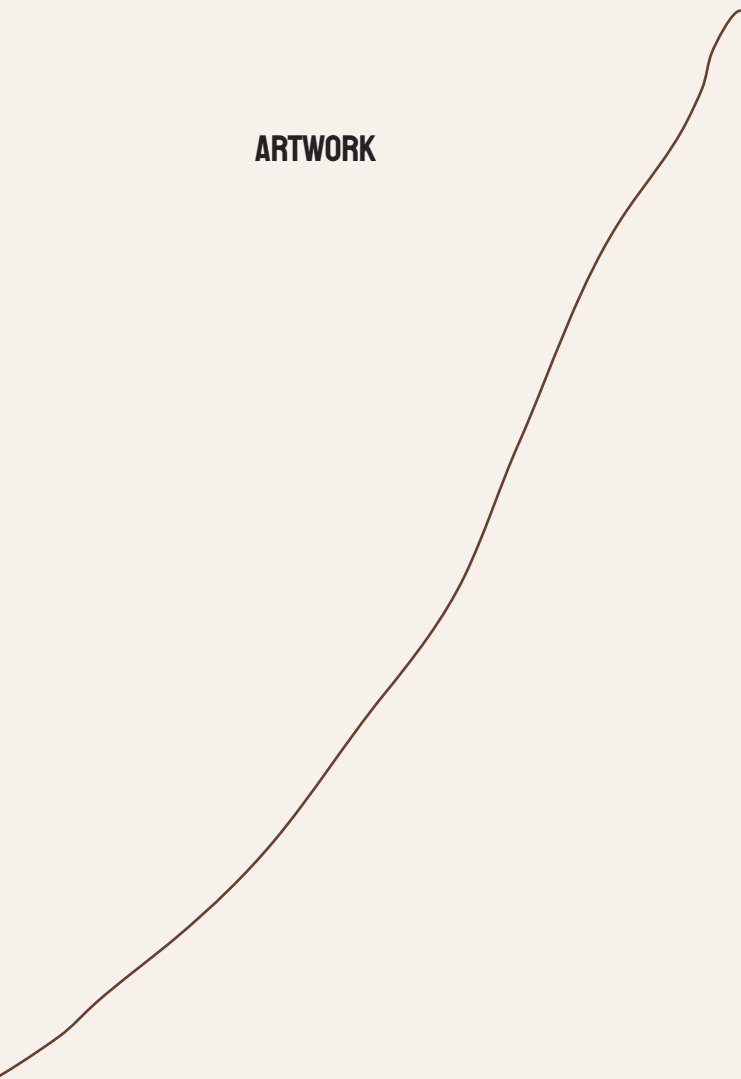
Petra: Yeah, sharpening our axes, drinking!

GM: **Brek, mark your Bond** advancement. The forge halls begin to grow quiet aside from the familiar sound of steel grinding against stone and the distant hammers deeper in the Overhold. Is there anything else anyone wants to do before we jump ahead to the next mission briefing?





ARTWORK



HISTORY & DEEPBEAST PRIMER

One hundred years ago, three comets struck Orrelia and formed the Three Craters. From the depths of those craters came the Deepbeasts, vast arcane adapted organisms that feed on magical energy the way predators feed on flesh. They navigate reality through arcane lines. They are drawn to spellcasting, relic activation and any event that disturbs the magical ecology of the world.

Dwarves are uniquely resilient to arcane corruption. That is why the Queen created **ANVIL**; a covert strike force that operates without generating arcane signals, resolving threats with kinetic force and structural disruption, they blow things up. They do not leave witnesses and are not officially acknowledged.

As for Deepbeasts, they are not defeated through attrition, they are taken care of by removing the conditions that sustain them. They retreat when arcane energy dissipates or the environment they're in collapses.

HISTORY & DEEPBEAST PRIMER

Deepbeast Detection Triggers:

- Active spellcasting or recent arcane discharge
- Enchanted or arcane infrastructure
- Relics or ruins with lingering arcana
- High residual magical contamination

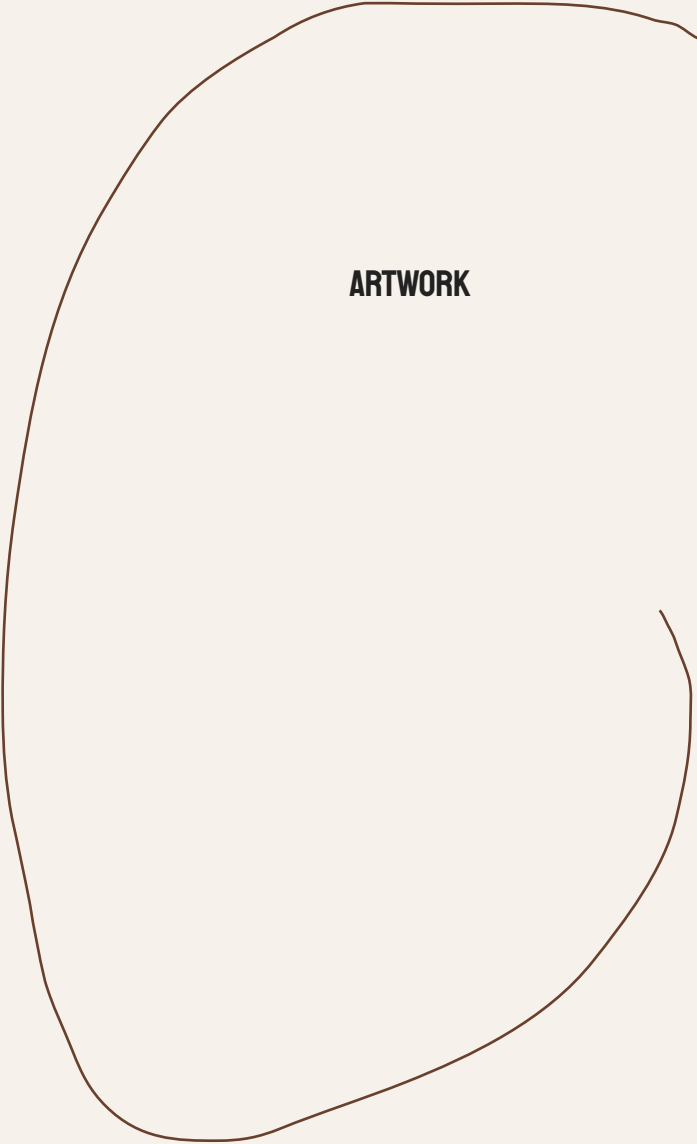
Deepbeast Behavior:

- **Drift:** Slow ambient movement. Minimal aggression unless disturbed.
- **Feeding:** Prioritizes arcane sources over physical targets. Disrupts spells and relics on contact.
- **Frenzy:** Triggered by high arcane density or disrupted feeding. Indiscriminate environmental destruction.

ANVIL does not generate arcane signals and is not inherently detected. However, explosives, structural collapses and interference with relic sites can release dormant arcane energy and escalate Deepbeast activity indirectly.

STARTER MISSION

See attached **FROZEN SIGNAL** mission sheet.



ARTWORK

BACK COVER